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Scripture and Gospel

A Note on Ecclesiastes

Sommer Motley

Ecclesiastes is my favorite book in the Bible. Its commentary on the meaning of life and the patterns of life speak deep into my soul. Just like most UM students, I am a perfectionist. I strive to get good grades, build my resume, have a decent social life, and somehow find a balance between all of these responsibilities and my personal well-being. I often find myself burned out within the first few weeks of every new semester, even when I have vowed to change my busy ways. I find that my life is packed with classes, work, church, student organizations, and applications for internships or graduate school. At the end of the day, I am bone tired and want nothing more than to crawl into a ball and not come out of my room for at least a week. At some point (around week 6 or 7), I realize that most of the things I am doing do not give me life. The things I am striving to achieve seem unattainable or unfulfilling and they leave me unsatisfied with my day. After one exam ends, I immediately study for the next. I, and many others, live our weeks thinking that if we just get through Friday all will be well again. We get lost in the hustle and bustle of life and yet don't feel like we are really living. For some people, reprieve comes from the one-week trip they take a year to escape their everyday life or the promise of a fancy degree at the end of four years. At some point, if you are like me, you come to realize that achieving the things you are striving for isn't enough. They are meaningless.

Ecclesiastes starts out by affirming this very sentiment, “ ‘Meaningless! Meaningless!’ says the Teacher. ‘Utterly meaningless! Everything is meaningless’” (Ecclesiastes 1:2 NIV). We toil all day long, work and work to no avail. Our souls long for more. Yet, we don't know what we are chasing more of. In an attempt to find the answer to this question, we try to learn more about the world. We seek wisdom and experiences that might tell us the meaning of this life. But

even that is meaningless, “for with much wisdom comes much sorrow; the more knowledge, the more grief” (Ecclesiastes 1:18 NIV). The truth about life is that it is filled with darkness and the more you study and know the Earth, the more evil and terrible things you find. You learn about the millennia of racism, abused children, greedy men, forgotten widows, and the selfishness of the human heart. In Ecclesiastes chapter 4 verses 1-3, not even the oppressed have a comforter and it says that “the dead are happier than the living” because they do not see the “evil that is done under the sun.” If we aren’t careful, we become hardened by the world and lose our ability to empathize. For some, the burden of the world is too much to carry and they drown themselves in distractions. For me, it is school and work.

We delight in fine foods and wine, relationships and sex, work, and in school. These things can capture our attention and drown out the knocking of our hearts for deeper meaning. They also can help us avoid feelings of emptiness. All of these things we delight in are not all bad and in fact, are gifts from God (Ecclesiastes 5: 19). However, they are not the source of our delight nor will they fill the hole in our souls that long for something deeper and more meaningful.

I find that the things that light me up and give me the most passion are things centered around people. My love for people and my compassion for their troubled hearts move me to action in my life. 1 John 3:11-19 describes love and how we are commanded to love one another. Ecclesiastes is an Old Testament book meant to verbalize the afflictions of human life and the human heart - one of its purposes is to help us realize our need for something, or someone, greater than the world we currently live in. It captures human desperation and affliction, and in turn, it helps us to understand our human conditions and limitations.

In chapter 7 of Ecclesiastes verse 29 it says that “ God created mankind upright, but they have gone in search of many schemes” (NIV). This verse reminds me that God created us to be righteous and to live in harmony with Him and His purpose for our lives. But since we are sinful in nature, we don’t fully buy into God’s plan and go in search of something better. We fall captive to the narrative the world and enemy tell us: that the world has something better to offer us than the Creator. God offers a simple answer to our afflicted hearts: the Gospel. He calls us to

follow Him, to love Him, and to surrender to Him. His way of life isn't overly complicated in nature or come with stipulations, it's so simple that our mind can't fathom a perfect love like His. The world plays off of this truth and offers complicated aversions to the simplicity of the Gospel, and they are filled with stipulations that cost us a bit of ourselves in order to receive a glimpse of what we truly long for. What we truly long for, and ultimately what we were created to do, was to know and love our God with all of our heart, mind, and soul. We long to put our mess into His hands so that He can wash it clean and make us more like Him.

Once we have this figured out, we have to understand how that changes us. What does it look like to live in the tension of knowing that the things we feel and experience in life are meaningless and also that we have a purpose greater than life itself? By knowing that God gave us gifts to enjoy, that He wants us to be happy in the times that are good, and that He is with us in the times that are bad, we can create a sense of peace. We can know the goodness of God and His perfect will while leaning on the Lord for our contentment in the waiting.

For me, God is the center of my life and yet I still live in this tension every single day. Life is hard and it's stressful and bad things happen. My heart is heavy with the evil of the world and the hurt that people cause one another. I sit in those feelings, allowing my heart to break for the things that break God's heart. Those feelings point back to the promise that God gave us for perfect justice and forgiveness, which allows me to have hope for a brighter tomorrow. When I feel insecure about my future, my finances, or my worth I allow my inadequacy to point me back to scripture and all of the ways God has shown up for His people since the beginning of time. When I am tempted by earthly answers to eternal questions, I don't allow myself to give parts of myself away to something that will never satisfy me. The glimpses of pleasure that the world tries to offer me no longer compare to the perfect love and goodness that God gives me freely every day.

Biblical Interpretation: Are We Picking and Choosing?

Brady Nichols

I recently had a conversation with two friends of mine who are nonbelievers. We were discussing the Bible and the basis for my decision to abstain from sex until marriage when one of them brought up Leviticus 19:19 (ESV): “You shall keep my statutes. You shall not let your cattle breed with a different kind. You shall not sow your field with two kinds of seed, nor shall you wear a garment of cloth made of two kinds of material.” This third point was the primary focus, as many Christians, myself included, frequently wear clothing made of two kinds of material, in direct violation of this apparently straightforward command. “If you follow the Bible in waiting until marriage”, the first friend wondered, “why don’t you follow this?” I tried to explain the reason for this, but my answer was neither satisfying nor in hindsight very sound. At this, my second friend jumped in and said “Well, it seems like you’re just picking and choosing then.” Though I disagreed, the reasoning to support my disagreement eluded me. This is my attempt at a more satisfying answer to their question.

Examining the Rulebook Method

In order to follow what the Bible says, we first need to understand how to read and interpret it. In this article, I would like to advocate for a framework of reading that simultaneously addresses the cohesiveness and diversity of Scripture and argue against an alternative one that diminishes its beauty and complexity. The latter method is commonly used among both believers and skeptics and consists of conceptualizing the Bible as essentially a rulebook; a collection of helpful hints or even strict commands on how to live a Godly life. From

this perspective, all biblical literature is a medium for God to tell us how to live to achieve the best results for ourselves, whether these are earthly or heavenly. If one follows the rules, it is supposed, one will reap benefits by earning God's favor. If not, the consequences will be severe. In this approach, when we read Bible passages our only goal is to extract a "moral" or some sort of takeaway that can then be directly applied to life. While there are some passages and even entire books (Proverbs, for example) that might look like rulebooks, this framework falls flat on multiple fronts.

The first way the rulebook method fails is it neglects to adequately acknowledge genre. Biblical literature is extremely diverse and deserves to be treated as such. The poetic beauty of the Psalms, the layered metaphor of Revelation, and the historical narrative of the gospels all merit their own interpretive lenses. Rather than seeking a "rule" or "moral" when we read them, we should take into account their intent, adjusting our expectations to match the tone it sets. We do this type of genre identification all the time with other works. For example, we have radically different expectations for a science textbook and *The Great Gatsby*. Reading *Gatsby* and expecting no-frills, concrete conclusions, or reading a science textbook and searching for metaphors and hidden meanings would yield ridiculous results. Both of these books communicate a teaching, but to uncover it we must use very different tactics. It is clear that determining what genre we are consuming is an essential piece of determining what the work is saying, and equally clear that we understand and apply this principle regularly. There is no reason the same rules shouldn't apply to the Bible, its component books, and even to individual passages within these writings.

The second shortcoming of the rulebook lens of interpretation is it overlooks important context. Often, when we search for a takeaway to directly apply to our own lives, we end up ignoring crucial details about the passage, such as who is writing, when they are writing, whom they are writing to, and more. Christians have frequently been guilty of this. For example, Philippians 4:13, one of the most quoted verses in the entire Bible, is constantly taken out of context. The verse reads "I can do all things through him who strengthens me,". On the surface, it appears to say that Paul, the writer, and by extension all followers of Christ, can accomplish

anything with God, which is not only inspirational but seems like something the Bible would say. However, when we look at Philippians 4:12 (“I know how to be brought low, and I know how to abound. In any and every circumstance, I have learned the secret of facing plenty and hunger, abundance and need”), we see that Paul is not writing about divinely aided accomplishment but divinely supported perseverance through all types of circumstances. The biblical context for this verse alters its meaning quite drastically. Historical context, even details not explicitly mentioned in the text, is also important for accurate interpretation. During the time Paul was writing to the Philippians, he was under house arrest in Rome for preaching the gospel, which rendered him unable to carry out his ministry. Knowing this is another clue that helps us interpret verse 13 as an encouragement for dealing with adversity rather than a declaration of the amazing things that can be accomplished through God. Through this example, it’s clear that both biblical and historical contexts matter immensely for the precise interpretation of scripture. The rulebook method often neglects to acknowledge these clues, which results in misinterpretation of the text.

The third important point the rulebook model misses is the perspective change that Jesus’ life, death, and resurrection cause for the Old Testament in particular. Jesus’ sacrifice for the forgiveness of humanity’s sins changed the rules of the game. It took the foundation laid by the Old Testament and fulfilled it (Matthew 5:17), changing the way we interact with it. Paul describes this in Galatians 2:21, saying “I do not nullify the grace of God, for if righteousness were through the law, then Christ died for no purpose,”. When Paul refers to the law, he means the Old Testament’s system of justification through sacrifices and works, a system that no human has ever been able to live up to. The key here is that Christ’s death provided a new path to righteousness, and Paul is reminding the Galatians that we must live in light of that new path. To read and follow the law as if nothing has changed is to “nullify the grace of God”.

Does this mean we throw away the Old Testament? Not at all. But we must interpret it in light of the resurrection. For example, when we read prophetic accounts of the arrival of the Messiah, we must recognize that the Messiah has already arrived. While ancient readers would have read the prophets and yearned for what was to come, we cannot and must not do the same. Nevertheless, there are many ways we can still learn from the prophets. We can recognize the

intense desire for a Messiah the Israelites felt, and we can observe how the life of Jesus fulfilled that desire. The same is true of Old Testament commandments regarding sacrifices, rituals, and justification. Although we are not obligated to perform them anymore, through reading about them we understand the difficulty (even impossibility) of justifying ourselves before God through our own efforts that necessitated a Savior. As Paul states in Romans 3:20, “For by works of the law no human being will be justified in his sight, since through the law comes knowledge of sin.” The law demonstrates to us the desperation of our need for grace, as it exposes the depth of our sin. This is still a valuable concept to learn, despite the fact that it is a drastically different application of the passage than we would have seen before the life of Jesus.

Bible as Story

If the rulebook approach misses these key elements of Bible reading, then how do we address them properly? To answer this question, I’ll turn to one of my favorite Christian authors: New Testament historian N.T. Wright. In his book *Scripture and the Authority of God* (and elsewhere), Wright advocates for reading the Bible as a story and emphasizes the unified message the entire Bible aims to get across. He splits the biblical story into five acts: the creation story from Genesis 1-2, the fall and its effects in Genesis 3-11, the story of ancient Israel spanning from Abraham to Jesus’ arrival, Jesus’ life and death, and finally, the aftermath of Jesus’ resurrection and the growth of the church. The beauty of this five-act system is that it organizes the Biblical story concisely and it even places the very reader of scripture within the fifth act. Understanding our place within the narrative of scripture, that is, where we are and especially where we aren’t, is critical to serious scriptural interpretation. As members of the fifth act, we must recognize that we are not living in ancient Israel, awaiting the Messiah, any more than we are inhabiting the Garden of Eden. This does not mean that the previous acts are insignificant or less valuable; after all, we would have no way of understanding our present act without first understanding the ones that came before. But, it does mean that our relationship to each act informs how we relate to the other acts.

Reading in this light not only gives us a better understanding of our relation to Scripture, but it also addresses the three shortcomings mentioned above: genre, context, and Jesus' sacrifice. While the rulebook approach sometimes prefers to ignore relevant context to extract a "moral" or "takeaway", the five-act system acknowledges that what was a "rule" in previous acts may or may not apply directly to us as members of the fifth. Once again, this doesn't give us a license to assume that none of the Old Testament (acts 1-3) applies to us, but rather bestows on us the responsibility to search historical and biblical context to determine the implications of the particular scripture we are reading. In some cases, we'll find that passages are useful to us for the same reasons they were to the original audience. In others, we'll see that their significance has changed over time; for example, from a sacrificial ceremonial law to a foreshadowing of the decisive sacrifice of Christ. Being open and committed to searching for and finding either result is a key component of reading the Bible in light of our place in the story.

This revised approach addresses the issue of the genre as well. Rulebooks do not make use of literary devices like metaphor, symbolism, and allegory; narratives, even non-fiction ones, on the other hand, make use of them frequently to convey meaning in a variety of ways. Understanding the Bible's status as not only a work of scripture but of literature unlocks a world of possible modes of expression. As a story, the Bible has access to a wide range of methods to express ideas, and we as readers are obligated to investigate and understand how it uses them. These methods often appear as a direct response to the particular demands of their corresponding act. For example, as the church began to spread around the world, letters became an extremely effective genre for disseminating information. In the later New Testament, we see Paul and others making frequent use of this genre as a result. On the other hand, the tribulations the Israelites faced over their tumultuous history made poetry, a genre especially suited for expressing lament and human emotion in a figurative manner, particularly useful. We see this in the Psalms, Lamentations, and other books as well. Understanding the act a particular book or even passage belongs to can shed light on the genre being used as well as potential reasons for its use.

Finally, the five-act system acknowledges the immense impact of Jesus' life, death, and resurrection on biblical meaning and interpretation. Simply put, all of biblical literature either foreshadows, describes, or reacts to these events. If the Bible is a play, the story of Jesus is the climax, an all-important development that alters the complexion of the entire work. It changes meanings, tones, and interpretations for the acts before it, and sets the stage for the act that follows. When we read the Old Testament, the five-act system demands that we do it through the lens of Christ, a principle that the rulebook approach ignores. When we read Isaiah and the prophets' predictions of a Messiah's arrival, we do not assume this figure is still to come. We know, as a result of the following act of the play, that he already has. The prophetic literature has now ceased to be a set of future predictions and has become a tool for members of the fifth act to recall the dire need and yearning for hope for a savior that has now been satisfied. Rather than learning from Isaiah the same things ancient Israelites did, we glean something entirely different in light of our new knowledge. We should take a similar approach to all the books in the Old Testament. As with context, we may find that the meaning of certain passages hasn't changed at all in light of Jesus' life. But often we will encounter a passage that has been transformed in some way and teaches us something entirely different than it taught those who read it while anticipating a Messiah.

A Return to Leviticus

This discussion of biblical interpretation now leads us back to the original question: Why do Christians not follow the rule laid out in Leviticus 19:19? To answer this, let's use the five-act system and the three disciplines outlined above, beginning with the genre.

The book of Leviticus is the third book in the Bible and part of what the ancient Israelites called the Torah, the first five books of the Bible. The name Leviticus indicates ties to the Israelite priesthood, as the Levites (members of the Israelite tribe of Levi), were priests in ancient Israel. But the book is also addressed to the entire community of Israel and provides information and directives from God regarding sacrificial rituals, worship of God at the tabernacle, and the holiness of all the people of Israel. The book is written primarily to record the

communications between God and Moses (and by extension, the nation of Israel) at Mount Sinai. The genre of this work is essentially a transcription of these communications, where God ordains his will for Israel and Moses passes the messages on to the people. As such, metaphor, symbolism, and other literary devices are not prevalent. Most of Leviticus is communicated directly and clearly, and the few stories contained in it describe implementations of the commandments laid out.

Now that we've seen what type of book Leviticus is, we can better understand the biblical and historical context of our passage. The verse in question here is found in a chapter of Leviticus particularly concerned with the idea of preserving the holiness of the Israelite community. In Leviticus 19:2, we see God commanding Moses to "Speak to all the congregation of the people of Israel and say to them, You shall be holy, for I the Lord your God am holy." This idea of holiness implies separation, and as such the commands that appear in Leviticus 19 aim to both distinguish Israel from neighboring nations and draw it nearer to the likeness of its God. In verse 19, the prohibitions on mixing are meant to differentiate Israel's customs from ancient pagan customs, where mixing of the sort mentioned in the verse was seen to have magical, supernatural power. Engaging in mixing could have caused the Israelites to participate in the pagan religions of their surrounding nations and drawn them away from God. As we can see, these divine bans were in no way arbitrary, even if they might appear that way to a modern audience. On the contrary, they were intentionally designed to prevent idolatry and help Israel keep the First Commandment: "You shall have no other gods before me" (Exodus 20:3). From this context arises a compelling argument as to why Christians do not adhere to this command. Given that this pagan association between mixing and divine power no longer exists, and as a result mixing does not tempt us to betray God, this commandment's purpose has been fulfilled. For a time, it was in place to prevent the Israelites from slipping into idolatrous, pagan religious practices. While the principle this rule upholds (resistance to idolatry) is still very necessary for modern Christians, the specific manner of idolatry avoidance it ordains does not apply to our modern context.

Jesus and the new order he inaugurated in Act 4 provide another argument against keeping this command. Jesus' death as a perfect, sinless man created a new and permanent means for the justification of all people before God. This means as Paul pointed out in Galatians 2:21 (quoted above), that the Old Testament law does not justify us before God. In Romans 3:28 Paul writes "For we hold that one is justified by faith apart from works of the law." None of the law, including but not limited to Leviticus, justifies us before the Lord. In light of the contextual indications that the purpose of Leviticus 19:19 has been served, the only reason to follow this law would be in hope of gaining favor with God by works. To continue to uphold this rule would be to seek justification through something other than faith in Jesus. Of course, there are still some Old Testament commandments that must be followed in Jesus' new order. But those tailored specifically to prevent idolatry in the context of ancient Israel simply do not fall into that category.

Conclusion

As Bible readers in the fifth act of the story of God's redemption of his creation, we have an obligation to work diligently at interpreting the Bible. God has given us his Word to declare his divine vision for creation, and in the power of the Holy Spirit, we have been tasked with understanding and living in light of that vision. When God speaks to us through the Bible, our listening should be reasonable and thoughtful. We must not reduce Scripture to a collection of rules, wisdom, and simple moral advice. Instead, let's embrace the diversity of the Bible with enthusiasm, read critically with an eye for context, and remember the climax of the story: the incredible news of Jesus. In doing so, we'll find the freedom to live in a renewed way in line with the vision of God, and the freedom to wear clothes with two kinds of fabric.

Faith Alone and Deeds

Daniel Koning

Jesus, God incarnate, lived a life without sin, but then chose to take the punishment for our sins onto himself to save us from the judgment we deserve. If we have faith and accept Jesus as our Lord and Savior, we are saved by our faith alone. This is a wonderful truth. Our actions and righteousness will always fall short of being good enough. As James 2:10 says, “For whoever keeps the whole law and yet stumbles at just one point is guilty of breaking all of it.” Trying to be redeemed by our actions and our upholding of religious law is unattainable. Yet, in scripture, we are very clearly called to act righteously, even though those righteous deeds cannot purify us or make us righteous.

The Bible is far more than a book of rules or a “how to” book on living a good life, but within it are commands that God gave the Israelites that also apply to us. The most famous of these are the Ten Commandments given in Exodus 20 and Deuteronomy 5 and the great commandment in Matthew 22:37-40, “you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind ... you shall love your neighbor as yourself.” If someone is a Christian they must believe this: God is the only god, the sovereign creator of all things who created us with a will to choose, and with this will we chose to reject God and so are deserving of God’s wrath. But God, out of love, chose to redeem us and take our punishment on himself through Jesus. God’s love for us is unfailing and no person, however special to you, will ever come close to matching God’s love for you. There is no other reasonable reaction to this than to love God and submit our lives to him. Nothing will ever mean more.

Every person submits their life to something. For one it may be gaining money and fame, for another knowledge and power, for still another pleasure and enjoyment in any number of forms. If we are to submit our lives to anything it should be that which is wholly good and has everlasting meaning. This is only true of God. As Galatians 5:6 says, “the only thing that counts

is faith expressing itself through love.” We are called to love God and love others as God has loved us. Furthermore, we are called to express that love. Not only is this the right thing to do, but it is also the only meaningful thing to do. This does not mean that other things in your life don’t matter. This expression of love can take a myriad of forms and can be present in vocations and avocations alike.

I was fortunate enough to have grown up in a household with Christian parents, to have gone to church my whole life, and to have been put through Christian school. I do not take these things for granted nor neglect the effect they have had on my beliefs. At that time I did not always accept God as good or believe that I should dedicate my entire life to him. That is something that I personally chose to do. Now that I am in college I have been given that choice again. I can reject God and the teachings I have heard and live however I want and get as much fun and excitement out of my college years. Again, I have chosen to follow God to the best of my ability. As someone who is chosen and loved by God, I do not desire to be a slave to sin. Of course, I have not gained some magical transcendence from temptation, but what I have gained is meaning. My faith, my God, and the community God has surrounded me with has given me a direction in my life unlike anything else I have done. I have found success in many things: I was All-State in swimming, had the lead role in performances, and was a top student in school, yet none of these things have been as important to me as my status as a child of God (see John 1:12-13). Being a Christian is part of my identity — it is who I am. God has done so much for me and has fulfilled me in a way that nothing else has been able to. When I feel that I am not good enough or that I am not valued because of what people think of me, I can rest in the assurance that God loves me. God is always present, even in my grief and fear. I will always fall short in some way. I will in school, work, relationships, and in my following of God. When that happens I feel like the work I put in doesn’t matter. But I know that my labor in the Lord is not in vain (1 Corinthians 15:58). People have the opportunity to experience God’s love and presence in a personal and fulfilling way and still choose to reject God’s plans for them and the fulfillment that living for him gives, and that is genuinely crushing to me. Love God and listen to him, he cares about you.

It is faith in Jesus and the acceptance of his sacrifice for our sins that saves us. However, genuine faith is not present without living accordingly. What a person believes is evident in how they live. If a person that believes a stock will boom they will buy that stock. If a person believes their home will be leveled by a storm they will relocate. If a person believes that the Bible is true and that Jesus died for their sins, they will listen to the Bible and follow God's word therein. Failure to be perfectly righteous is not a sign that a person lacks faith, as no one but Jesus was perfectly righteous, which is why we need grace. However, apathy for one's own deeds is a profession of one's apathy for God. A faith without corresponding action is no faith at all.

James 2:14-17, "What good is it, my brothers and sisters, if someone claims to have faith but has no deeds? Can such faith save them? Suppose a brother or a sister is without clothes and daily food. If one of you says to them, 'Go in peace; keep warm and well fed,' but does nothing about their physical needs, what good is it? In the same way, faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead."

Here, James is clearly saying that faith is made complete through action. Yes, faith alone is necessary to accept the forgiveness God has granted. However, as James said, faith without corresponding action is dead.

Living out our faith is also important because Christianity and faith in Jesus are more than personal. When Christians do things, people notice. I have seen in the news too many times about scandals of priests assaulting children or pastors having sex scandals. As Christians, our image and how we act reflect the image of God for people that do not know him. When we sin, we distort that image. I have heard people say, "I like Jesus, I just don't like his followers." I don't know their life experiences, but those people may be entirely right in saying that. What we do as Christians matters because people see it and people are affected by it. When Christians hurt each other nonbelievers see that Christians are a people that hurt one another. When Christians hurt nonbelievers they feel that Christians are a people that hurt nonbelievers. We are called as Christians to glorify God and bring light to the nations. So many people who have professed themselves as Christians have brought darkness. A discrepancy between the call for Christians, myself included, to love and the way we may actually act is sinful, evident, and repugnant. We

are called to “live such good lives among the pagans that, though they accuse you of doing wrong, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day he visits us (1 Peter 2:12).”

This notably is not calling us to simply rebuke the pagans for their living, but rather to demonstrate to them the glory of God through our own living, highlighting the importance of how we live. Christians are not perfect and because of this broken world cannot be perfect, yet it is our responsibility as Christians to magnify God’s glory through our love.

To explore the reverse, righteous living alone cannot save us. No one is perfectly righteous, pure, or without sin. All sins separate us from God and any sin makes us deserving of God’s judgement. Because we are sinful beings and any sin makes us an enemy of God, the only way to be saved is by faith in Jesus. For non-believers, their good deeds cannot save them. A person that denies God could devote their life to good works or humanitarian aid and what they do would be a good thing. But just as faith is dead without works, trying to live a good life separate from God is like trying to grow a plant in infertile soil. Trying to grow the plant is good, but it will wither quickly.

Faith and acceptance of God’s forgiveness are save us from our sins. Because of this, Romans 6:14-15 says, “For sin shall no longer be your master, because you are not under the law, but under grace. What then? Shall we sin because we are not under the law but under grace? By no means!” Through our faith, we are no longer slaves to sin, but slaves to righteousness. Grace is not an invitation to sin, but an invitation to love. Christians are clearly called to live righteously and this does not contradict the fact that faith alone is what saves. We were each created to do good works and to love one another. As Ephesians 2:8-10 says, “For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith — and this is not from yourselves, it is a gift from God — not by works, so that no one can boast. For we are God’s handiwork, created in Christ Jesus to do good works, which God prepared us in advance to do.” Yes, it is faith alone that saves. No amount of service can forgive a man or relieve a woman. Yet, with all this being true, our faith is dead without action and so much is to be missed if we do not live according to our faith.

A Whole “Lot” of Mercy

Kevin Fan

Content Warning

This article discusses Genesis 19, which is one of the darkest chapters in the whole Bible. Because the goal of this article is to exegete the text, it will not shy away from the difficult topics that it covers. However, that does mean that the article will address graphic and disturbing content that will be hard for some readers to deal with. Some of this content is sexual in nature (however, rest assured that there will be no images/sounds embedded in the article; all of it is in writing). The exceedingly sinful actions that the men and women take in this true, Biblical account are NOT a reflection of true Christian morality in any way and are NOT endorsed by the Lord as “godly behavior.”

Introduction

I—jokingly, of course—believe Genesis 19 to be one of the most unfortunately placed chapters in all of the Bible. Imagine this: the skeptic resolves to read the Bible for the first time, starts in the very beginning (naturally), but then arrives at Genesis 19 and puts down their Bible in disgust at the utterly depraved history that it records. The new believer, whose heart is freshly captivated by the gospel of Christ, begins their maiden voyage through God’s Word and is promptly greeted by an account so dark and troubling that it teaches them the hard lesson that the “good book” does not speak about morally good people (save for one huge exception). Or even consider longtime believers who, as a New Year’s resolution, recommit to reading the whole Bible in one year; long before they hit the inevitable stormy sea known as Leviticus, they find themselves shipwrecked on the island of Genesis 19. No matter who reads it, Genesis 19 is not a chapter that leaves the reader in a lighter mood after reading it.

But maybe that’s the point. Perhaps the Bible is not a book that is meant to only make us feel good every time we read it. Perhaps the Scriptures, as they record God’s dealings with sinful

men, are meant to challenge our thinking, make us feel uncomfortable, and reveal our shortcomings. Perhaps in doing so, the Scriptures become the instrument by which the God who wrote them reveals His character and conforms our lives and our hearts to the image of His Son. Or, as Jesus says in John 17:17, “Sanctify them in the truth; your word is truth.”

We have a lot to learn—about God, about ourselves, and about the saving work of Christ—from passages like Genesis 19. If the *whole* Bible points us to Christ and His gospel, then we ought to examine them with care and ask God to teach us His character and His heart. With that in mind, I believe that a proper exegesis of Genesis 19 reveals the depths of humanity’s depravity, the ferociously holy and just nature of God, and the unconditional nature of His grace; an examination of the whole counsel of Scripture in conjunction with this passage also reveals that though we repeatedly mean things for evil, God ordains them for good and for His glory.

My exegesis of Genesis 19 can be organized into four major points (as you can see, I am quite gifted in my use of alliteration):

1. The **angels**
2. The **announcement**
3. The **annihilation**
4. The **aftermath**

The Angels

“The two angels came to Sodom in the evening...”

The passage starts with two angels arriving at the gates of Sodom in the evening. But before we even discuss their interaction with Lot, it is important to review the Biblical narrative thus far.

In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth (Gen. 1:1). Everything that has ever been made was made by Him, and He created man in His own image (Gen. 1:27). Adam and Eve walked in an intimate relationship with God and in the paradise of Eden, but all of that was shattered when they disobeyed God’s command to not eat the fruit of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. Before casting them out of the garden, God applied the curse of sin to the human race and, in a shocking turn of events, declared that there would be a future Savior

who would crush the head of the serpent but suffer in the process (Gen. 3:15). The rest of the book of Genesis (and until Jesus arrives in the Gospel accounts, the Bible as a whole) traces that “seed of the woman” as God’s people anticipate the arrival of their wounded victor.

While waiting for their promised Savior, humans do a really good job of messing up the world that God made for them. They kill each other, cheat each other, and hate each other; all of this is done in a spirit of active rebellion against God. Their natural inclination is to sin against God and commit all kinds of evil, and God’s wrath against their sin is revealed in His flooding of the whole earth in Genesis 6. But in doing so, He graciously keeps the promise alive by saving one man—Noah—and his family through the floodwaters in an ark. Humanity is then given a chance to start over, but they quickly fall back into rebellion against God; this reaches a climax in their attempt to exalt themselves above God in building the tower of Babel (Gen. 11:4). God responds by confusing their languages and scattering the nations across the earth.

But God is still working to bring His promises to pass. He calls a man named Abram (whom He later renames Abraham) and makes a covenant with him. In Abraham’s family, God says, “all the families of the earth shall be blessed” (Gen. 12:3), and his descendants will be as many as the stars in the sky. Abraham, despite being an old man at this point, believes in the promises of God and is counted as righteous (Gen. 15:6). However, it isn’t long before Abraham and Sarah (then Abram and Sarai) try to force the issue and have Abraham sleep with Sarah’s servant Hagar. Hagar gives birth to a boy named Ishmael, but God tells Abraham that the covenant promise will not be carried through Ishmael, but Isaac, to whom Sarah will give birth herself.

At the same time, Abraham also has a nephew named Lot. In Genesis 13, he and Lot separate, with Abraham moving to the land of Canaan and Lot moving into the valley and eventually settling down in the city of Sodom. Genesis 13:13 says this about the city’s inhabitants: “Now the men of Sodom were wicked, great sinners against the LORD.”

Sodom is then caught up in a military conflict, which results in Lot and his family being taken prisoner and Abraham needing to rescue him. He does so by winning a military victory against the coalition of kings who had fought against Sodom and a neighboring city called

Gomorrah. Instead of moving elsewhere, however, Lot and his family settle back into Sodom despite the depraved nature of its residents. This becomes a major problem when God reveals to Abraham that He is going to judge Sodom and Gomorrah for their sins. Abraham, recognizing that Lot is among those seemingly marked for destruction, begins to intercede on behalf of the city. The discourse between God and Abraham ends with God declaring that “for the sake of [ten righteous people] I will not destroy it” (Gen. 18:32, parentheses mine).

Judgment looms over Sodom. Lot is stuck in Sodom and unaware of the situation. And it is in *this context* that Genesis 19 begins:

The two angels came to Sodom in the evening, and Lot was sitting in the gate of Sodom. When Lot saw them, he rose to meet them and bowed himself with his face to the earth and said, “My lords, please turn aside to your servant's house and spend the night and wash your feet. Then you may rise up early and go on your way.” They said, “No; we will spend the night in the town square.” But he pressed them strongly; so they turned aside to him and entered his house. And he made them a feast and baked unleavened bread, and they ate. (Gen. 19: 1-3)

The angels that visit Sodom in this passage appear to look like men. We know this because Lot, in an act of genuine hospitality, treats them like men by offering to wash their feet, giving them beds, and even preparing a meal for them to eat. Based on their interactions, there's not much evidence to suggest that Lot knew that these men were actually angels; however, there definitely is room to argue that he at least saw them as distinguished visitors to the city. But regardless of what kind of men Lot thought they were, he clearly embodies the hospitable heart of Hebrews 13:2, which says, “Do not neglect to show hospitality to strangers, for thereby some have entertained angels unawares.”

The angels initially resist this offer of hospitality, but Lot demonstrates the genuine nature of his offer by insisting that they spend the night at his house. Lot sees it unfit for them to spend the night in the town square and, at least partially, has their personal comfort in mind. But Lot, being a longtime resident of Sodom at this point, also knows the nature of the men that live

in this city; he doesn't just think leaving them to sleep in the town square is unfit for them, but also unsafe. And he's right because the passage continues to read:

But before they lay down, the men of the city, the men of Sodom, both young and old, all the people to the last man, surrounded the house. And they called to Lot, "Where are the men who came to you tonight? Bring them out to us, that we may know them." Lot went out to the men at the entrance, shut the door after him, and said, "I beg you, my brothers, do not act so wickedly. Behold, I have two daughters who have not known any man. Let me bring them out to you, and do to them as you please. Only do nothing to these men, for they have come under the shelter of my roof." But they said, "Stand back!" And they said, "This fellow came to sojourn, and he has become the judge! Now we will deal worse with you than with them." Then they pressed hard against the man Lot, and drew near to break the door down. But the men reached out their hands and brought Lot into the house with them and shut the door. And they struck with blindness the men who were at the entrance of the house, both small and great, so that they wore themselves out groping for the door. (v. 4-11)

The reason why it isn't safe for these angels to be sleeping outside is because Sodom is full of wicked men. And the sin that characterizes the men of Sodom is that of homosexuality in both desires and practices. The Bible consistently, repeatedly, and clearly takes the position that homosexuality is a form of sexual sin (e.g. Lev. 18:22, 20:13; Rom. 1: 26-27, 1 Cor. 6:9), and it is clear in this passage that homosexual behavior doesn't just occur in this city; it is part of the norm. "The men of Sodom, both young and old, all the people to the last man, surrounded the house" (v. 4).

The residents of Sodom, having heard that two men have entered the city and are staying with Lot, demand Lot hand them over to have sex with them. And these men, in addition to not caring that homosexual activity is unnatural, also aren't particularly worried about the angels' consent; when Lot tries to refuse them, their response is to try and break the door down and have

sex with them anyway. Their intention isn't merely to have sex with these men but to commit gang rape.

But Lot isn't innocent in this passage either: in fact, he behaves just as wickedly as the men of Sodom do. When trying to dissuade the men from gang raping the two angels, he makes them this offer: "I beg you, my brothers, do not act so wickedly. Behold, I have two daughters who have not known any man. Let me bring them out to you, and do to them as you please. Only do nothing to these men, for they have come under the shelter of my roof" (v. 7-8). Lot is offering up his two virgin daughters to this crazed mob to take the place of the two men. *He's offering up his daughters to be abused by rapists.* This is a ridiculously inexcusable offer on his part. Lot, in this passage, sins against God in an act of extreme moral compromise.

The men actually pick up on this and mock Lot, saying, "This fellow came to sojourn, and he has become the judge! Now we will deal worse with you than with them" (v. 9). In one breath, they demonstrate their lack of respect for Lot in calling out his hypocritical plea for moral behavior and recommit to their efforts to get to the angels. They press hard against Lot (v. 9) in their determination to go through with their intention to rape the angels and reserve a worse fate for Lot himself ("Now we will deal worse with you than them"). Thankfully, the angels demonstrate their power by managing to pull Lot back inside his house and incapacitate the men with blindness. Though they are angels of God and serve a righteous God, they graciously deliver Lot despite the grievous sin he has just committed.

The Announcement

"Anyone you have in the city, bring them out of the place... the Lord has sent us to destroy it."

After the mob is taken care of, the angels finally reveal themselves as messengers from the LORD. The next verses read:

Then the men said to Lot, "Have you anyone else here? Sons-in-law, sons, daughters, or anyone you have in the city, bring them out of the place. For we are about to destroy this

place, because the outcry against its people has become great before the LORD, and the LORD has sent us to destroy it.” (v. 12-13)

This is the warning that the angels give to Lot: *judgment is coming*. It’s a warning of impending wrath and destruction against the city as decreed by God Himself. But it’s also a gracious warning because Lot himself doesn’t deserve to hear this. Though he doesn’t participate in the homosexual activity that Sodom is notorious for, he is also a sinner and has just demonstrated the depths of his depravity by offering up his daughters to be sexually abused. He deserves to perish with the rest of them, and yet, he is given the opportunity to hear the warning, gather his loved ones, and run before disaster hits.

Despite his sinful behavior in this account, Lot is a man of faith at this point. The Apostle Peter refers to him as “righteous Lot” in the New Testament and describes him as being “greatly distressed by the sensual conduct of the wicked (for as that righteous man lived among them day after day, he was tormenting his righteous soul over their lawless deeds that he saw and heard)” (2 Pet. 2: 7-8). Now, Lot is not righteous in the sense that he is morally upright before God on his own; in fact, nobody is, “for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Rom. 3:23). If we all went before God with our own righteousness, every one of us would be considered among “the wicked.” The distinction between the righteous and the wicked in 2 Peter 2 is *not* the righteousness inherent to a person, but rather the righteousness imputed to the sinner by faith. Peter is simply saying that Lot is saved.

So Lot is a man of faith at this point, and like any Christian who falls into serious sin, his conscience is awakened by this warning from the angels. Here is his response:

So Lot went out and said to his sons-in-law, who were to marry his daughters, “Up! Get out of this place, for the LORD is about to destroy the city.” (v. 14)

His response is to warn his family. He is a righteous man by faith, and he knows that when God says something, He means it. But here’s the tragic consequence of his years of moral compromise and living in a city notorious for his sin: again, any call he makes to heed the word

of God or live morally falls on deaf and haughty ears. He informs his sons-in-law (betrothed, not married) of the wrath to come, but “he seemed to his sons-in-law to be jesting” (v. 14). Though he goes to them and tells them to flee with him and away from the wrath of God, they just think he’s joking around.

Perhaps (and this is just a guess on my part) the reason why they think he’s joking is that for all of Lot’s warnings for them to leave, he himself lingers around instead of leaving. He doesn’t seem in much of a hurry to leave the city as soon as possible after hearing the news despite the clear warning that he’s been given. As God’s wrath nears, Lot tarries in his own home.

The Annihilation

“Then the LORD rained on Sodom and Gomorrah sulfur and fire... out of heaven.”

Night fades, morning dawns, and the city of Sodom is about to experience the destructive judgment of God. But there’s one problem: Lot is still in the city. So here’s what the angels do to rectify this problem:

As morning dawned, the angels urged Lot, saying, “Up! Take your wife and your two daughters who are here, lest you be swept away in the punishment of the city.” But he lingered. So the men seized him and his wife and his two daughters by the hand, the LORD being merciful to him, and they brought him out and set him outside the city. And as they brought them out, one said, “Escape for your life. Do not look back or stop anywhere in the valley. Escape to the hills, lest you be swept away.” (v. 15-17)

There is a lot to unpack here. First, the angels urge Lot *again* to leave Sodom as quickly as possible. The son-in-laws have ignorantly decided to remain behind, but there is still time to save his wife and daughters. Lot has waited through the night to leave, but surely he would act quickly to heed the second warning, right?

Wrong. Despite the punishment of Sodom looming over his head, Lot takes his sweet time to get out of there. The angels (who must have been *so* frustrated by now) now take action:

they grab Lot and his family and bring them outside of the city. And after they bring them outside of the city, they instruct Lot for the third time (v. 17).

One must ask: why are these angels taking these painstaking steps to ensure the survival of *one* sinner and his family? The reason behind their visit, the reason behind their endurance of seeing such sin in the city of Sodom, the reason behind their repeated warnings is this: they are agents of the LORD, and the LORD is being merciful to Lot. And because He has determined to save Lot, a righteous man by faith (let's remember Abraham's intercession for any "righteous men" in Sodom), God has in turn decided to endure his wicked transgressions, his hypocrisy, his moral compromise, and his lack of urgency in fleeing the city with much patience. Note that God does not offer this mercy to everyone in the town of Sodom; in fact, He has already determined to wipe them all out swiftly. Also, note that the angels are sent specifically to Lot; they encounter *him* when he is sitting at the gate, they enter *his* house, they bring the warning to *him* (it should be noted that for however long the angels spend in the city, they don't go around warning as many people as possible), and they instruct him to bring whoever *he* has in the city out before it's too late (v. 12). This is an awful lot of kindness (no pun intended) that is being shown to one sinner among many.

But even when it seems like Lot is finally in the clear, he continues to demonstrate a bewildering lack of haste in his fleeing of the city, as evidenced by his response to the angels:

And Lot said to them, "Oh, no, my lords. Behold, your servant has found favor in your sight, and you have shown me great kindness in saving my life. But I cannot escape to the hills, lest the disaster overtake me and I die. Behold, this city is near enough to flee to, and it is a little one. Let me escape there—is it not a little one?—and my life will be saved!" He said to him, "Behold, I grant you this favor also, that I will not overthrow the city of which you have spoken. Escape there quickly, for I can do nothing till you arrive there." Therefore the name of the city was called Zoar. (v. 18-22)

Here stands Lot with his family on the outskirts of Sodom. The wrath of God looms over the city, and the angels are urging him to escape with haste and not look back (v. 17). They seem awfully

concerned with Lot's survival. But Lot doesn't flee immediately; rather, he stops and *asks the two angels* if he can escape to a different place that he thinks is close enough to flee to in time. Despite the overwhelming amount of patience he has already been shown so far, Lot suddenly doubts that God will leave him enough time to flee to the hills. This man may be a man of faith, but his faith proves to be rather weak at this moment.

God's faithfulness to him, however, remains strong. And the LORD, in both His righteousness and grace, holds off on dispensing His wrath to allow Lot enough time to escape to safety in Zoar. When the angel says, "I can do nothing till you arrive there" (v. 22), he is speaking about a constraint that God, in His sovereignty, has placed on him. God will not allow His instruments of wrath to lift a finger until His people are safely out of harm's way.

The sun had risen on the earth when Lot came to Zoar. Then the LORD rained on Sodom and Gomorrah sulfur and fire from the LORD out of heaven. And he overthrew those cities, and all the valley, and all the inhabitants of the cities, and what grew on the ground. But Lot's wife, behind him, looked back, and she became a pillar of salt. (v. 23-26)

The image of the LORD raining fire and sulfur down on Sodom and Gomorrah may be a jarring one, but it serves as a prime example of God's wrath over sin and His righteousness in punishing evildoers. For the rest of Biblical history, it serves as a warning to future generations to follow the LORD and not fall into the horrifying wickedness that these cities fell into. Sodom and Gomorrah are mere shadows of what we all truly deserve before a holy God, for "none is righteous; no, not one" (Rom. 3:23) and "the wages of sin is death" (Rom. 6:23). He reserves the right to punish sin, and the totality of the destruction left behind in the valley speaks to the harrowing consequences of our wrongdoing.

But what do we make of the pillar of salt? Well, I do not know the exact reason why she turned into a pillar of salt, but what I do know is that Lot's family was commanded to not turn back as they fled Sodom. Lot's wife disobeyed that command, and she paid dearly for it. She

may have been standing outside of Sodom, but her heart was clearly still there; because of that, she joined the rest of Sodom and Gomorrah in their fate.

After reading of the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah, we then reunite with Abraham, the man who had previously interceded on behalf of any righteous people in the city. He returns to the place where he met with God to intercede for Sodom, and this is what he sees:

And Abraham went early in the morning to the place where he had stood before the LORD. And he looked down toward Sodom and Gomorrah and toward all the land of the valley, and he looked and, behold, the smoke of the land went up like the smoke of a furnace.

So it was that, when God destroyed the cities of the valley, God remembered Abraham and sent Lot out of the midst of the overthrow when he overthrew the cities in which Lot had lived. (v. 27-29)

In the end, Abraham's request was answered: his nephew Lot, the righteous man in Sodom, was spared. God had fulfilled both His decree to judge Sodom for its sin and spare any righteous people in Sodom from judgment. As he overlooks the valley, Abraham sees a dual picture of God's faithfulness and His wrath.

The Aftermath

"Thus both the daughters of Lot became pregnant by their father."

Lot's story doesn't end with his flight from Sodom, however; it ends in a cave with his daughters.

Now Lot went up out of Zoar and lived in the hills with his two daughters, for he was afraid to live in Zoar. So he lived in a cave with his two daughters. And the firstborn said to the younger, "Our father is old, and there is not a man on earth to come in to us after the manner of all the earth. Come, let us make our father drink wine, and we will lie with

him, that we may preserve offspring from our father.” So they made their father drink wine that night. And the firstborn went in and lay with her father. He did not know when she lay down or when she arose.

The next day, the firstborn said to the younger, “Behold, I lay last night with my father. Let us make him drink wine tonight also. Then you go in and lie with him, that we may preserve offspring from our father.” So they made their father drink wine that night also. And the younger arose and lay with him, and he did not know when she lay down or when she arose. Thus both the daughters of Lot became pregnant by their father. The firstborn bore a son and called his name Moab. He is the father of the Moabites to this day. The younger also bore a son and called his name Ben-ammi. He is the father of the Ammonites to this day. (v. 30-38)

The record of Lot’s life ends with a twisted bit of irony: the very daughters who he offered up to a crazed mob take turns getting him drunk and sexually abusing *him* in order to have children. The children of these incestuous unions, as we might know from reading the rest of the Old Testament, are responsible for hundreds of years of suffering for God’s people—a depressing end to a depressing chapter of the Biblical narrative.

Learning from Sodom and Gomorrah

“And as Isaiah predicted, ‘If the Lord of hosts had not left us offspring, we would have been like Sodom and become like Gomorrah.’” - Romans 9:29

The destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah in Genesis 19 is one of the darkest and hardest accounts to read in the Bible. But God, in His wisdom, moved Moses to include it in Scripture for God’s people to read today. So we need to ponder the question: *what exactly can we get out of reading an account like this?*

Well, I think a good place to start is to acknowledge that not everything we read in the Bible is going to be easy to swallow. We live in a broken world that suffers from the consequences of sin, and the Bible uses a lot of words to tell us the reality that *things are not as*

they should be. If you're looking for a place to escape reality, the Bible is the worst place to go because it forces you to see the world as it currently is without sugarcoating any of it. The Bible, therefore, is not going to be a book that speaks fondly of our human potential to do the right thing; rather, through stories like Genesis 19 that feature attempted homosexual gang rape, a father offering his daughters for sexual abuse, and incestuous affairs, the Bible acts as a mirror through which we must peer into our deeply depraved souls.

The testimony of the Bible is this: beginning with Adam and Eve's disobedience in the garden, humanity has been living in active rebellion against God despite being created for a relationship with Him. In other words, "by the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners" (Rom. 5:19). In our default position, we are "dead in our trespasses and sins" and "by nature children of wrath" (Eph. 2:1, 3). We are all guilty of sin before God, for "none is righteous; no, not one" and "for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" (Rom. 3:10, 23); even our good deeds cannot spare us from the punishment we are justly due, for "we have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment. We all fade like a leaf, and our iniquities, like the wind, take us away" (Isa. 64:6). This sin problem is not merely found in the things we do, but at the very core of our being. Jeremiah 17:9 famously says, "The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick; who can understand it?"

Genesis 19 fits perfectly with the overarching testimony of Scripture in this regard: *it tells us that we are not good.* It reveals just how darkened the human heart is, the evil things that we are all capable of, and in turn, our desperate need for a Savior. While most of us may not be keen on committing gang rape, offering up our daughters, or pursuing incest, the fact of the matter is that we are all, in one sense or another, guilty of sin and liable to eternal condemnation in hell. These specific sins may not appear on our resumes, but that doesn't excuse us from the laundry list of iniquities that we have defiled ourselves with. Jesus says in Mark 7: 21-23, "What comes out of a person is what defiles him. For from within, out of the heart of man, come evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder, adultery, coveting, wickedness, deceit, sensuality, envy, slander, pride, foolishness. All these evil things come from within, and they defile a person." Different

people struggle more with different types of sin, but we ought to know that ultimately, we don't have a moral high ground to stand on in comparison to the people of Sodom.

We all deserve punishment for our sins. And in light of the depth of our depravity, Genesis 19 also offers a clear picture of the ferociously holy and just nature of God. Psalm 7:11 says, "God is a righteous judge, and a God who feels indignation every day"; Psalm 11:5 adds, "The LORD tests the righteous, but his soul hates the wicked and the one who loves violence." God's attitude towards sin in His world is not one of mild disapproval, but intense hatred; as a passionate lover of all things good, it is also part of His nature to hate what is *not* good. Habakkuk addresses God in this way: "You who are of purer eyes than to see evil and cannot look at wrong" (Hab. 1:13). The moral purity and holiness of God are diametrically opposed to sin in all cases, and since the God of the Bible is primarily concerned with His own glory, He does not take kindly to the open mockery of His name and His character; "do not be deceived: God is not mocked, for whatever one sows, that will he also reap" (Galatians 6:7).

Because the citizens of Sodom and Gomorrah have made a mockery of God's good design for marriage and sex, their condemnation is just. Though God does not always choose to punish sin immediately (He will, however, punish all sins *eventually*), Sodom and Gomorrah is in the Bible because 1) it was a real historical event and 2) it reveals the fierce wrath of God over our transgressions. Sodom and Gomorrah demonstrate that God *cares* about righteousness and is zealous in His love for good and His hatred of evil. The obliteration of Sodom and Gomorrah points to the obliteration and eternal judgment that we have earned with *our* sin. Our God is not a God who sits idly by as we work to ruin His good world; rather, He is faithful to actively execute justice and display His wrath over sin as He sees fit. At this moment in history, the citizens of Sodom received the punishment that they deserved.

But Lot doesn't. Although Genesis 19 reveals Lot to be just as wicked as his Sodomite neighbors, God sends two angels to rescue him and his family from the impending destruction. And here's why that is so significant: in a passage where both the depravity of man and the holiness of God are clearly demonstrated, the divine rescue operation that is sent into the city of Sodom serves to reveal a third truth to us: the unconditional nature of God's grace.

Lot deserves punishment. *He offered up his own daughters, for goodness' sake!* This is a man whose actions clearly demonstrate that he is not worth saving. Consider how he separates from Abraham (whose family carries the promises of God) and moves into a town whose inhabitants are notorious for committing vile sexual sins. Also consider how, after he is rescued by Abraham, he moves right back into the city. Finally, consider the lack of influence that his witness has on his loved ones: though he is a man of faith, his sons-in-law think he's joking about the wrath of God and does not take his warning seriously. His wife disobeys the command to not look back, and she turns into a pillar of salt. He offers up his virgin daughters to a mob attempting to rape two men, and they in turn get him tipsy and sleep with *him*. There is nothing that distinguishes Lot from his contemporaries in this passage.

Except for one thing: *God chooses* to show him kindness. Lot is a righteous man; that is, he is saved. And God is determined to spare him from the wrath that is to come. He may be lost and wandering in a land of wickedness, but he is *the one lost sheep* that God is willing to leave the ninety-nine to save. This is *truly* amazing grace! Because he belongs to God, God sends two angels into that wasteland to save him; and He does so according to the riches of *His* grace and mercy and not according to any merit that Lot offers. Lot's story serves to demonstrate to *us* that God's mercy is great, and His grace is free; our salvation, therefore, has nothing to do with anything we bring to the table—works *or* character—because in and of ourselves, we are exactly like the world out of which we were saved. Yes, Genesis 19 reveals to us how sinful we are and how holy God is, but it *also* is a story of the amazing and immeasurable saving grace that God has for His people. It tells of His patience and kindness towards us, for “the Lord is not slow to fulfill his promise as some count slowness, but is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance” (2 Pet. 3:9). It reflects how Christ, in the face of our unbelief, our rejection, our wickedness, and our hard hearts, traveled to a place far worse than Sodom to save a wretched people like us. It should amaze us that God would send two angels to Sodom to rescue someone like Lot, but it should amaze us *even more* that God would send His only Son to the cross to rescue *us*!

And as unbelievable as it may be for someone like Lot to offer up his virgin daughters in the place of sinless angels, it is *infinitely more unbelievable* how God would offer up His perfect and only begotten Son in *our* place to save us *while we were His enemies!* “But God demonstrates his love for us in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us” (Rom. 5:8). Lot’s story is *our* story, oftentimes more than we ourselves are willing to admit. We may be like Lot in our hypocrisy, our moral compromise, and our hearts’ attachment to the sinful things that the world offers, but God’s grace proves time and time again to be greater than our sins. And just as the angels were faithful to save him in the face of his wickedness, God is faithful to save us in spite of ours because He *already knows* the ones whom He has come to save. And finally, in the midst of our sins today, His promise is for us: “If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1 Jn. 1:9).

Genesis 19 reveals our wickedness, God’s holiness, and the abounding grace He has for us in His Son. But if we zoom out and examine the *whole* of Scripture in conjunction with this passage, we come to one final conclusion: though we work things for evil, God works all things for good and for His glory.

After the events of this chapter, we don’t hear from Lot again. He and Abraham go their separate ways for good.

The rest of the book of Genesis unfolds in this way: Abraham and Sarah finally *do* give birth to Isaac, the child of the promise. The promises of God are then bequeathed from Isaac to his younger son Jacob (another example of unconditional election), who in turn has twelve sons. One of them is Judah. Though Judah’s family falls into disrepair and he ends up sleeping with and impregnating his daughter-in-law, Jacob declares this prophecy over Judah at the end of his life: “The scepter shall not depart from Judah, nor the ruler's staff from between his feet, until tribute comes to him; and to him shall be the obedience of the peoples” (Gen. 49:10). In the familial line of Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and now Judah, we see that the promise regarding the “seed of the woman” is still alive and well. Judah’s daughter-in-law, Tamar, gives birth to their son Perez, whose descendants are as follows: “Perez fathered Hezron, Hezron fathered Ram, Ram fathered Amminadab, Amminadab fathered Nahshon, Nahshon fathered Salmon” (Rth. 4:

18-20). In Matthew's Gospel account, we learn that Salmon eventually married a Canaanite woman named Rahab (her story is very similar to Lot's in how God rescues her from the destruction of Jericho). After they marry, Salmon and Ruth have a son named Boaz.

Another one of Jacob's sons, Joseph, is sold into slavery in Egypt by his own brothers (Judah included). And though he suffers for a short while in Egypt, God raises him up to lead Egypt through a famine and even save the lives of the brothers who had sold him into slavery. At the end of the book of Genesis, Joseph utters these famous words: "As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good, to bring it about that many people should be kept alive, as they are today" (Gen. 50:20).

Lot has two children with his daughters: one named Moab, and one named Ben-ammi. Moab, of course, is the father of the Moabites. Long after the events of the book of Genesis, after God delivers Israel from Egypt, the Moabites are still around as Israel settles into the Promised Land. Their most notable mention in the rest of the Bible is at the beginning of the book of Ruth, which unfolds this way:

In the days when the judges ruled there was a famine in the land, and a man of Bethlehem in Judah went to sojourn in the country of Moab, he and his wife and his two sons. The name of the man was Elimelech and the name of his wife Naomi, and the names of his two sons were Mahlon and Chilion. They were Ephrathites from Bethlehem in Judah. They went into the country of Moab and remained there. But Elimelech, the husband of Naomi, died, and she was left with her two sons. **These took Moabite wives**; the name of the one was Orpah and **the name of the other Ruth**. (Rth. 1: 1-4)

Hundreds of years after Lot's daughters get their father drunk and sleep with him to preserve their family line, Ruth the Moabite becomes Naomi's daughter-in-law. What happens next is tragic: Orpah and Ruth's husbands both die. But in an amazing act of loyalty to her mother-in-law, Ruth puts her faith in the God of Israel and journeys with Naomi back to Bethlehem. And according to God's providence, Ruth meets a young man named *Boaz*.

What we intend for evil, God ordains for good.

You see, when Lot's daughters tricked him into drinking wine in order to sleep with him, their intentions were purely selfish. They simply wanted to preserve the family line and, as a result, acted in pure wickedness against God *and* their father Lot. But what they meant for evil, God meant for good; through this act of depravity, God brings forth the nation of Moab. Out of the Moabites, he brings forth a woman named Ruth. And in ordaining a meeting between Boaz and Ruth that results in Boaz marrying Ruth through kinsman-redemption, God uses the sin of Lot's daughters to give His people a beautiful picture of the gospel and of Christ as our greater Kinsman-Redeemer.

But the story doesn't end there: Salmon and Rahab have a son named Boaz, Boaz meets Ruth, and they have a son named Obed. And the book of Ruth closes out with this: "Obed fathered Jesse, and Jesse fathered David" (Rth. 4:22). One thousand years after David's life, a baby is born in Bethlehem and is given the name of Jesus. The seed of the woman was preserved through the union of Boaz and Ruth. And this Jesus, a descendant of both Abraham and Lot, was not just a man; He was both truly God and truly man. In His life, He lived the perfect life that we could never live and died the death that we all deserve to die. On the cross, He bore the sins of all of God's people and, though we deserved the same punishment that Sodom and Gomorrah received, God the Father turned His unvented wrath on His Son and crushed Him instead of us. Three days later, Jesus rose again from the dead, securing a victory over sin and death that we could never win and now, He lives today to be the Savior of everyone who simply puts their trust in Him alone for the forgiveness of their sins. The Apostle Peter spoke of His life, death, and resurrection in this way:

Men of Israel, hear these words: Jesus of Nazareth, a man attested to you by God with mighty works and wonders and signs that God did through him in your midst, as you yourselves know— this Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men. God raised him up, loosing the pangs of death, because it was not possible for him to be held by it. (Acts 2: 22-24)

That is, though wicked men killed the Son of God and meant it for evil, God had planned it from the beginning and meant it for good and to save a multitude of sinners. What we mean for evil, God always ordains for good.

Heeding the Warning

“Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life; whoever does not obey the Son shall not see life, but the wrath of God remains on him.” - John 3:36

We are wretched sinners. God ferociously hates sin. His grace, however, abounds for His people. And though we may mean things for evil, God works them all for good.

From these four takeaways, we could derive many different points of application from this passage. We could apply this passage by examining our lives for any sin that we might be caught in, pondering anew the seriousness of sexual sin and pursuing purity in response, or by resolving to trust God to help us to stop longing after our old lives in light of our new identity in Christ; in other words, “I have decided to follow Jesus: no turning back, no turning back.” This passage could even inform our evangelism by reminding us that nobody is too far gone for God to save them. But, in light of Good Friday and Resurrection Sunday passing us by for another year, allow me to zero in on one application point in particular: **have you heeded the warning?**

If you currently are not a Christian, if you have not yet put your faith in the person and work of Christ alone to save you from your sins, the worst thing you could do is read this article and continue on in your unbelief. While I have your attention, I *beg* of you: listen closely to what I am about to say!

You are a wretched, hell-deserving sinner. You may not sin the way Lot sins, you may not sin the way I sin; but the Bible says that “None is righteous; no, not one” and that “all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God” (Rom. 3:10, 23). No matter how good you think you are in comparison to your neighbor, the record of your life is that of a guilty rebel who stands condemned as an enemy of God. Whatever “good” you think you do in this life will not change that verdict. God is holy, and God is just; He *will* punish you because He is perfectly righteous and He hates sin.

There is but one remedy to your problem, and that remedy is found in the person of Jesus Christ. He is truly God and truly man, the Son of God and the Son of Man; on earth, He lived the life that we could never live, died the death that we all deserved, and rose again to offer eternal life to all who believe. You see, God isn't only a God of justice, but a God of love; "For God so loved the world that he gave his only begotten Son, that whoever believes in him should not perish but have everlasting life" (Jn. 3:16). He lived for sinners, He died for sinners, He rose again for sinners, and He is alive today; *today*, He lives to save anyone who will call upon His name, for "everyone who calls on the name of the LORD will be saved" (Jl. 2:32). But also hear this warning from Jesus himself: "unless you believe that I am he you will die in your sins" (Jn. 8:24). Hear His declaration two verses after John 3:16, where He says: "Whoever believes in him is not condemned, but whoever does not believe is condemned already, because he has not believed in the name of the only Son of God" (Jn. 3:18).

Heed the warning. Flee from the wrath to come before it is too late. Believe in the Lord Jesus Christ, that He died for your sins and rose again to conquer sin and death on your behalf; put your trust in Him alone to save you. *Do not remain in Sodom*. Do not remain under the curse of sin with the wrath of God looming over you, because the wrath of God is coming against all who do not repent and believe in the gospel. It doesn't matter what you've done or who you've done it with, because the blood of Christ is sufficient to cover all of your sins. His grace is greater than the worst things you have ever done, and He is willing to forgive the most hideous of your sins. You only need to flee into the arms of Jesus; when you do, *do not turn back*.

If you are a Christian today; if you've already heeded the warning and fled into the arms of Jesus, God bless you. You've fled into an everlasting refuge. But now, Jesus is sending *you* back out into the world to preach His gospel. Hear Him when He says: "As the Father has sent me, even so I am sending you" (Jn. 20:21) and when He commands: "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you. And behold, I am with you always, to the end of the age" (Matt. 28:

18-20). Dear Christians, we must obey this command. We must go into Sodom and call our fellow Lots to repentance and faith in Christ.

We also need to consider the message that we preach. Do we warn people? Do we preach the holiness and wrath of God? Or are we satisfied with only telling people that Jesus loves them?

Loved ones, that is not enough. Jesus did not preach the gospel this way, and neither did the apostles. Consider Paul's letter to Romans, which contains the most exhaustive gospel presentation in all the Bible. He says, "For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes, to the Jew first and also to the Greek. For in it the righteousness of God is revealed from faith for faith, as it is written, "The righteous shall live by faith" (Rom. 1: 16-17).

But how does he start his gospel presentation? Verse 18 reads, "For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who by their unrighteousness suppress the truth." Or consider Paul's presentation of sin in Romans 3, where he writes:

None is righteous, no, not one; no one understands; no one seeks for God. All have turned aside; together they have become worthless; no one does good, not even one. Their throat is an open grave; they use their tongues to deceive. The venom of asps is under their lips. Their mouth is full of curses and bitterness. Their feet are swift to shed blood; in their paths are ruin and misery, and the way of peace they have not known. There is no fear of God before their eyes.

Now we know that whatever the law says it speaks to those who are under the law, so that every mouth may be stopped, and the whole world may be held accountable to God. For by works of the law no human being will be justified in his sight, since through the law comes knowledge of sin. (Rom. 3: 10-20)

This is hard to hear, but it is necessary to preach because the grace of God towards sinners in Christ is seen all the more beautifully against the backdrop of our depravity and the wrath that we deserve.

But now the righteousness of God has been manifested apart from the law, although the Law and the Prophets bear witness to it—the righteousness of God through faith in Jesus Christ for all who believe. For there is no distinction: for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified by his grace as a gift, through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus, whom God put forward as a propitiation by his blood, to be received by faith. This was to show God's righteousness, because in his divine forbearance he had passed over former sins. It was to show his righteousness at the present time, so that he might be just and the justifier of the one who has faith in Jesus. (Rom. 3: 21-26)

But God demonstrates his love for us in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us. Since, therefore, we have now been justified by his blood, much more shall we be saved by him from the wrath of God. For if while we were enemies we were reconciled to God by the death of his Son, much more, now that we are reconciled, shall we be saved by his life. More than that, we also rejoice in God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have now received reconciliation. (Rom. 5: 8-11)

Therefore, as one trespass led to condemnation for all men, so one act of righteousness leads to justification and life for all men. For as by the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man's obedience the many will be made righteous. Now the law came in to increase the trespass, but where sin increased, grace abounded all the more, so that, as sin reigned in death, grace also might reign through righteousness leading to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord. (Rom. 5: 18-21)

For the wages of sin is death, but the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord. (Rom. 6:23)

There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus. (Rom. 8:1)

This needs to be our message. We must preach about sin, we must preach about God's wrath, and we need to preach the saving work of Christ in light of what He saves us from. We must tell the world that the wrath of God is coming and that the *only* escape is through His Son. "I am the way, the truth, and the life; no one comes to the Father except through me" (Jn. 14:6).

No matter how foolish we may look, no matter the price we might pay, this is something we must do. Because thanks to Sodom and Gomorrah, we know what lies ahead for all who do not belong to Christ.

The Image of God

Kyle Speelman

There are four Hebrew words that are often translated to “image” in the Old Testament. The first is *tselem*, most often translated as image or likeness, but can also mean semblance, shadow, or outline. The second is *demut*, which also means likeness or semblance, particularly in appearance or action, but the root of *demut* is the Hebrew word for “blood,” so it often means resemblance in a parent-child sense. The third is *pesel*, which refers specifically to carved images, perhaps idols, often something that is worshipped. The fourth is *temunah*, again often translated as “likeness,” but more so in the context of representation or semblance, for example between a painting of an animal and the actual animal, or between different animals of the same species.

Translating each of these words only to “image” or “likeness” doesn’t capture all of their meaning. Recognizing which Hebrew word is being translated to “image” can add more depth to the passage. And knowing when one of these words is translated into something else can also add meaning to the passage and insight into connecting several passages together. All of this can help us understand our roles as image bearers of God.

Genesis 1:26-27 says: “Then God said, ‘Let us make mankind in our image, in our likeness, so that they may rule over the fish in the sea and the birds in the sky, over the livestock and all the wild animals, and over all the creatures that move along the ground.’ So God created mankind in his own image, in the image of God he created them; male and female he created them.” Here, the word “image” is translated from *tselem*, and “likeness” is translated from *demut*. So being made in God’s image, in this sense, could mean in appearance, but also according to *demut* shows our relationship to God: we are His children. He loves us as a father loves a child. But He also created us to be in His semblance in that we are supposed to be perfect, as He is perfect.

This brings up an interesting tangential question: are we no longer in God's image because of the fall? After all, mankind is no longer perfect after choosing to disobey God in Genesis 3. I think we still are in God's image. For one, we are still referenced as such in later passages (Gen. 5:3 and 9:6, to name a few). In some sense, we are still in God's image in that we were created to be able to make choices, as God also has made choices, and, ultimately, chose to give us choice. Mankind chose sin in Genesis 3, but what we do with our choices now can still be a reflection of God's image.

God speaks again about images in the Ten Commandments: "You shall not make for yourself a carved image, or any likeness of anything that is in heaven above, or that is in the earth beneath, or that is in the water under the earth. You shall not bow down to them or serve them, for I the Lord your God am a jealous God, visiting the iniquity of the fathers on the children to the third and the fourth generation of those who hate me, but showing steadfast love to thousands of those who love me and keep my commandments" (Exodus 20:4-6). Here, "carved image" is translated from *pesel* and "likeness" is *temunah*, different words than the ones used to describe man as the image of God. A carved image is something that is made to mimic something that already exists, as a reminder or a representation. God commands us not to create such things, I think, because they do not do the original creation justice. Humans are creative, we can create good things, but the things we create are on a different level than what God creates, and we shouldn't try to replace things that God created. That doesn't mean we can't use our creativity to paint or draw or build things that are inspired by creation. It means we shouldn't replace creation with things we create or put our works on the same level as God's.

Pesel also often refers to things that are worshipped. Israel at this point would have just come up out of Egypt, a land that was filled with carved images of the various Egyptian gods. They were literally surrounded by them, bombarded by Egyptian culture during their time in slavery. That is, until God upturns all of Egyptian culture by showing His power over all their major gods through the ten plagues. Then Israel leaves for the desert, free of all influence of Egyptian culture but still malleable to adapt to the culture of any surrounding nations. God commands them not to be like Egypt, not to make images to worship. Why? Because we are the

image! We don't need *pesel* because we are God's *tselem*. God already created an image to resemble Him. We cannot create an image representation of God because anything we could create would not be good enough. God created His *tselem* and it is us, and the way He created us is good.

And yet, not long after Israel received the Ten Commandments, while Moses is on the mountain speaking to God, Israel is creating a carved image, a golden calf, a *pesel*, if you will, although that word is not used in the text. It does say in Exodus 32 that Aaron fashioned the calf with a tool, which sounds like a carved image. The people of Israel proclaim this golden calf (although a better translation for calf is "young bull") as the gods who brought them out of Egypt. However, in the next verse they still offer a feast to the Lord. I heard an interpretation once that the golden bull isn't necessarily an image of a god, but rather a mode of transportation. Israel was looking for a god to lead them in the desert, and since the Lord was still on the mountain with Moses, they created the bull as something for the Lord to ride as He leads them through the wilderness. Aaron seems to know that creating the bull was wrong, because, when Moses confronts him, he leaves out the part about fashioning it with a tool, making it sound like the creation of the bull was a miracle. Using a tool would make the bull a carved image, a *pesel*, a direct contradiction to the Ten Commandments. Whether Aaron was creating a god or a vehicle for the Lord, it was still clearly wrong, and Israel was punished for it.

There are many other instances in the Bible of God's fury against images and idols. In particular, *tselem* is used many times to refer to the images that the Israelites destroyed of foreign gods when entering their country, particularly that of the Babylonians. *Tselem* is also the word used to describe the image of King Nebuchadnezzar that was created in Daniel 3, when Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refuse to bow down and worship it, and God saves them from the furnace. God protects them when they obey the command to not recognize created images. Images created by man are not the true image of God, mankind himself is the *tselem*.

God is clear: no images are to be made with the intention of worshiping them or subverting God's own creation. Not of any god or idol or resembling anything in creation. God is

not like the gods worshipped by others, we are not to have a *pesel* to represent God, we are the *tselem*. But surely we aren't to worship other people like the Egyptians worshipped their *pesel*. So what does being an image of God actually mean for us?

Daniel 3:19, in the context of the Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refusing to bow to the *tselem* of King Nebuchadnezzar, says: "Then Nebuchadnezzar was filled with fury, and the expression of his face was changed against Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. He ordered the furnace heated seven times more than it was usually heated." *Tselem* is the word translated to "expression" in this verse. This doesn't really change what the verse means in context. It does, however, offer another side of what *tselem* means. An expression follows the thoughts of the being creating the expression. Since we are *tselem*, we are one form of God's expression. There's a lot of weight in how we express ourselves to others, since, for better or worse, we are showing God's expression then. We should try, therefore, to convey God's expression in everything we do.

Psalms 39:5-6 says:

"Behold, you have made my days a few handbreadths,

and my lifetime is as nothing before you.

Surely all mankind stands as a mere breath! Selah

Surely a man goes about as a shadow!

Surely for nothing they are in turmoil;

man heaps up wealth and does not know who will gather!"

In these verses, *tselem* is translated as "shadow." This shows another nuance to *tselem*. A shadow follows the movements of the object creating the shadow. If we are the shadow of God, our actions should be like His. We should live like Jesus, to do what He would've done, to love as He loves. A faithful image looks like the object it is based on, so a faithful *tselem* of God accurately reflects Him. The way we go about our lives should say something about the God we serve. We are God's image; we don't want to convey a false or untrue image of God. We need to

be good stewards of the image, so the choices we make should resemble God and what He is like.

Psalm 73, in the context of talking about wicked people, says “Like a dream when one awakes, O Lord, when you rouse yourself, you despise them as phantoms” (verse 20). *Tselem* is translated as “phantom” here. This shows God’s opinion of those who do not convey a true image of Him. Wicked people are not a faithful *tselem* of God. We will never be perfect, never live up to the standard of being God’s perfect image, and of course there is forgiveness for when we fail. But being the image of God is serious. It should impact everything we do. We may be the only way the world sees God. We should live intentionally to give them a good representation of who God is.

In the New Testament, an expert of the law asks Jesus about the greatest commandments. Jesus responds by saying “‘Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.’ This is the first and greatest commandment. And the second is like it: ‘Love your neighbor as yourself.’ All the Law and the Prophets hang on these two commandments” (Matthew 22:37-40). There was no dispute at the time about what the greatest commandment was: everyone agreed it was to love God. However, many Rabbis at the time debated what the second most important law was. But Jesus put the commandment of loving our neighbor on the same level as loving God; it is not the second most important law, it is like the first, equal to it. Our neighbor is the image of God, too. We can show our love of God by loving His image. Together, by loving our neighbor and being loved by our neighbors, we demonstrate the Kingdom of Heaven. “The only thing that counts is faith expressing itself through love” (Galatians 5:6b). We have the opportunity to love our neighbor, and through that, we love God, showing the world that we are made in His image.

God made us in His image, as a child can resemble his father. Our image reminds us that we are children of God, that He loves and cares for us as a Father. At the same time, God has called us to steward His image well. We can show the world what God looks like, how He acts, and most importantly how He loves, by showing that love and kindness to others. We are called to love and respect God’s image in the form of our neighbor. We love God by showing that same

love to others. And we advance the Kingdom by showing the world what it looks like to follow God. That's what it means to be made in His image.

Life and Campus

The Gift of Rest

Kyle Speelman

“Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy. Six days you shall labor and do all your work, but the seventh day is a sabbath to the Lord your God. On it you shall not do any work, neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your male or female servant, nor your animals, nor any foreigner residing in your towns. For in six days the Lord made the heavens and the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, but he rested on the seventh day. Therefore the Lord blessed the Sabbath day and made it holy.”

Exodus 20:8-11

The Sabbath is one of the more well-known laws in the Bible. Many Christians are familiar with the idea of not doing work on Sundays or going to church on the Sabbath. But what actually is the Sabbath? What makes a day a Sabbath? Is Sunday the Sabbath, as many Christians call it? Sabbath is mentioned many times in the Bible as something the Jews follow. They observe the Sabbath from sundown on Friday to sundown on Saturday. Is Saturday the Sabbath, as many Jews call it? The Jews, at least in Biblical times, had many laws regarding what you are and are not allowed to do on the Sabbath. These laws are often used as examples when talking about how Christianity offers freedom from the rigorousness of Jewish law. So which way is it? Should we not bother with the Sabbath laws? Or is Sabbath still an important practice? I know many Christians who don't consistently observe a Sabbath. If our week is too busy with school or work, is it okay to skip it? And if the topic is so complex, why should we bother with it at all? It is a complex topic, but that doesn't mean we should shy away from it. The Sabbath is an important practice that can be very refreshing for those who choose to practice it.

The Sabbath has its roots in Genesis 2. God creates the Heavens and the Earth in six days, and on the seventh day, when He finishes the work, He rests. “Then God blessed the

seventh day and made it holy, because on it he rested from all the work of creating that he had done” (Genesis 2:3). From the beginning, God sets aside the seventh day as a special day of rest. It is a holy and blessed day; God clearly values rest and the seventh day. This is the beginning of Sabbath.

This emphasis that God puts on the Sabbath is clear to the Israelites. It is one of the Ten Commandments that God gave to Moses on Mount Sinai, where again God cites how He rested on the seventh day, so the Israelites should rest as well. And not just them, but their households, neighbors, and animals. It is meant for the entire community of Israelites to rest together. God goes even further with Sabbath for the Israelites, in Exodus 23 and Leviticus 25, commanding them to observe a Sabbath year every seven years. “For six years you are to sow your fields and harvest the crops, but during the seventh year let the land lie unplowed and unused. Then the poor among your people may get food from it, and the wild animals may eat what is left. Do the same with your vineyard and your olive grove” (Exodus 23:10-11). The purpose of this is more than rest, it is to let the land heal from six years of intensely being worked. It helps the poor by giving them food (something also shown in how God commanded them to harvest their land during the other six years), and it protects the wild animals living in the land by giving them food. Sabbath, then, in this case is a time of attention and healing for often less well-noticed aspects of God’s creation. On top of that, given what we know today about the impact of intensive farming on the land and the importance of crop rotation, this is a very forward-thinking law that also protects the land from overuse. The land ends up being more fruitful in the six years than it would be if it were overworked without a break. There is a direct parallel between this and our lives: the land is meant to rest on a seven year period as we are also meant to rest on a seven day period.

When I think of resting for a day, I think of all the lost time to make progress on work. Now more than ever, I feel the need to constantly be working to get ahead; the idea of stopping for a full day doesn’t necessarily fit the mindset of a modern-day worker. That may also have been the case in Biblical times, as we read in the book of Nehemiah. Nehemiah was written when the Israelites were returning to Jerusalem from exile. It was a time of repentance, a time of rebuilding, a time of recentering on God’s laws. Sabbath is one of the laws specifically

mentioned. The people were struggling to follow God when the nations around them were not, and this led to them often conducting business on the Sabbath. In order to better follow the Law of Moses, they made several commitments, one of which being: “When the neighboring peoples bring merchandise or grain to sell on the Sabbath, we will not buy from them on the Sabbath or on any holy day. Every seventh year we will forgo working the land and will cancel all debts” (Nehemiah 10:31). This shows a way that Israel will be different from the nations around them: they will not do business on the Sabbath, a difference that the other nations would certainly notice when the Israelites wouldn’t allow them to enter Jerusalem to sell goods on the Sabbath. It also introduces the idea that Sabbath might be about more than just resting, as forgiveness is also mentioned. Naturally, this is something that we are called to every day, not just the Sabbath, but observing a Sabbath certainly frees up some additional time to commit to the habit of forgiveness.

Sabbath, then, is a break in the normal routine of the week, an opportunity to rest from the work that fills the rest of the week, regardless of how busy the people around us are, and a chance to devote that time to God and others. It is an intentional choice not to do work, one that can be difficult to make considering how busy our lives are. In that sense, observing a Sabbath requires a level of trust in God. Sabbath is His gift; He wouldn’t give us something that would hinder His idea of success for us. So when a weekly Sabbath rolls around, and not all of the work from the week is done, we have to trust that either that work isn’t as important, or that God will provide another time to do it. Sabbath is an opportunity to exercise and strengthen our trust in God. That doesn’t mean we can be poor stewards of the rest of our week and use Sabbath as an excuse to not do work. In order to practice a Sabbath, there are sacrifices that often need to be made throughout the week in order to be able to rest on the seventh day. But there is something beautiful about being able to rest for a full day. Rest, for me at least, takes time to enter into: taking a break for a few hours on a day that I spent mostly working may be restful in the moment, but it doesn’t last. But after taking a full day off, I’ll feel refreshed for much longer. It is a gift from God to be able to receive that lasting rest. We live very busy lives, especially as 21st century college students. A lot is expected of us, and there are many classes, clubs, and more that demand our time. Sabbath can feel like just another demand of our time, something that can be cut when other things come up, but a Sabbath rest only becomes more important the busier our

lives are. We need the rest now more than ever, surely God would know that and wouldn't ask something of us that is impossible when considering the modern philosophy of constantly trying to work harder and get ahead of everyone else.

After all, the God of the Universe rested too. As stated in Genesis 2 and Exodus 20, God created the Heavens and the Earth in six days, and he rested on the seventh. If God rested on the seventh day from His work, then shouldn't we do the same? God has given us an example of what it looks like to balance work and rest. He has shown us a way that we can be like Him. Additionally, by choosing to be like God in this way, we are also showing the world around us what our God looks like. Inevitably people will notice when we only spend six days a week working. They might notice us doing more work on a project during the week to not spend any time on it on the Sabbath. They might see the extra rest that we feel during and after a Sabbath. And through those differences in the way we live, they will see a glimpse of the God we serve, one whose "yoke is easy and burden is light" (Matthew 11:30). There's an opportunity to share the Gospel in everything, and Sabbath is no different.

Despite this, many Christians still don't observe a consistent Sabbath. We even see several instances in the Gospels of Jesus disobeying the Sabbath laws of the time. Mark 2:23-3:6 recounts two of these instances. Here we see the disciples picking grain on the Sabbath. The Pharisees rebuke them, and Jesus responds with the story about David and his companions eating the consecrated bread before saying that "the Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath" (Mark 2:27). The story that immediately follows is about Jesus healing on the Sabbath, where he asks whether it is lawful on the Sabbath to do good or evil. In this, we see Jesus emphasizing a different aspect of God: He values loving others. Elsewhere, Jesus summarizes the Law and the Prophets into "Love the Lord your God" and "Love your neighbor as yourself" (Matthew 22:37-40). These are the two greatest commandments. By healing on the Sabbath, Jesus shows that it is more important to love those around you than to follow the particulars of Sabbath law. The Sabbath is not a set of regulations; rigorously keeping up with what one can and can't do would never be restful. It's about taking a break from regular rhythms, to step back from the intensity of work and rest, to have space to see the needs of others and fill them.

We aren't required to do or not do certain things on a Sabbath, the goal is rest, in whatever form that looks like to us. Colossians 2:16 says "do not let anyone judge you by what you eat or drink, or with regard to a religious festival, a New Moon celebration or a Sabbath day." What is restful for one person may not be restful for another; there shouldn't be judgment on that. I've often followed a general rule where my Sabbath rest looks like the opposite of my work for the week. When I've worked a more physically demanding job during the week, rest looked like a nap and a break from physical activity, maybe engagement in a mentally stimulating activity. During school semesters or internships, rest has looked like a walk, playing sports with others, or maybe still a nap, but always less mentally intensive activities. Even if those things aren't necessarily what I want to do, I try to refrain from doing the same things I do throughout the week, because I know that will end up making me more tired. I've found that to be a good way to purposefully engage in rest, but if it doesn't work for you, don't do it. Sabbath is not meant to be an obligation or another box to check off; the opportunity to rest is yours to take.

And, ultimately, the gift of rest from God is just that: a gift. It is our choice to receive it. Personally, I think it would be unwise to refuse a gift from God, but that is your choice. I don't think it's necessarily a sin to neglect the Sabbath. After all, Jesus says in Matthew 11, right before the story that was already recounted in Mark 2, that He is the ultimate source of rest. Our Sabbath rest is fulfilled in Jesus. But observing the Sabbath is still a great way to accept this rest.

For me personally, Sabbath has been a journey of growing in my faith and trust. Growing up in a Christian home, my family didn't do any work on Sunday, and didn't do anything that might cause anyone else to have to work as well. I enjoyed that day and never questioned why we did it. But when I got to high school and my life got busier, I stopped practicing Sabbath regularly, to the point where, by the end of high school, I didn't observe a Sabbath at all. My weekends were always full of doing homework, college prep, whatever I needed to do to ace my classes, maintain extra-curriculars, and look good on college applications. I graduated high school feeling burnt out, knowing college might only be worse. Something had to change.

When I came to Michigan as a freshman, there were a lot of ways that I was hoping to make my faith my own, to see how I would fare as a Christian on a large public campus. One of

the things I was hoping for was to restart my practicing of the Sabbath, so I picked up that habit I had as a child of not doing work on Sundays. And I was mostly successful, I didn't do work on Sundays, except when I had a lot of work, then I finished it on Sundays. I didn't get a lot out of that Sabbath experience because I didn't put much effort into it, and I didn't rest when I needed it most. Then Covid happened and all the college rhythms that I had just started getting used to were turned upside down.

When I came back to campus as a sophomore, my understanding of the importance of rest was slowly increasing, and I wanted to be more intentional about observing the Sabbath, and it's something that I've kept up on since then. It's been a very intentional choice. I eventually switched from observing Sabbath on Sunday to Saturday, because at the time I had commitments for most of the day on Sunday. Almost all were Church related, but it no longer felt restful to do those things on the Sabbath.

It was difficult to want to rest during the busy weeks, knowing my schoolwork would just sit there, not getting done, until I got back to it the next day. And every time I put down my work to rest on Saturday, God provided me with another time to still finish everything on time. Even in my busiest semesters, on the engineering grind, on the career search, there was space to practice Sabbath, and God gave me rest through it. I finish my Sabbaths feeling far more refreshed than I would from taking smaller breaks throughout the week. My encouragement to you would be to consider observing the Sabbath too. Take the opportunity to slow down for one day. Spend time in community with others. Read scripture. Take a nap. Six days are for the normal rhythms of life. Setting aside one day makes a big difference.

God offers us a promise regarding the Sabbath in Isaiah 58:13-14:

*“If you keep your feet from breaking the Sabbath
and from doing as you please on my holy day,
if you call the Sabbath a delight
and the Lord's holy day honorable,
and if you honor it by not going your own way*

*and not doing as you please or speaking idle words,
then you will find your joy in the Lord,
and I will cause you to ride in triumph on the heights of the land
and to feast on the inheritance of your father Jacob.'*
For the mouth of the Lord has spoken."

God's gift of rest has been very impactful in my life. It's an opportunity to slow down and take a break in our own lives, and it gives us a chance to see the needs of others and serve them. It's a chance to exercise trust in God that we don't need to work constantly to keep up with the rest of the world. That's not our highest calling anyways, it is to love God and love others. Sabbath offers us one way to engage with that by creating a time and a space where we can focus intentionally on Him. And in Him we will find joy and rest.

Bend, not Break

Isabelle Degaynor

This semester, I am studying abroad in Paris. Living in a new country, you meet a lot of people from a wide variety of backgrounds with different thoughts, perspectives, and life experiences. While on spring break in Spain, I met five lovely women from across the globe. One, who I will call Sarah, lives in the Netherlands and is heavily involved in astrology and other spiritual practices. She has consulted mediums and shamans and used psychedelics. She believes in past lives and studies numerology. She is also an independent woman with strong business skills and a kind heart.

As I sat and listened to her around the lunch table, I couldn't help but question what I believe. In my opinion, it takes a lot theologically to be a Christian. Christians have to deal with unavoidable truths that upset 21st-century sensibilities, such as how God told the Israelites to slaughter entire nations in the Old Testament . We have to wrestle with tough questions, like how salvation works for people who die without ever having heard about Jesus.

The Gospel is simple. The rest of it? Not so much.

One thing Sarah talked about was a back-to-nature approach. She and I both believe that our bodies and the earth (nature) are interconnected. We both agree that our body speaks and tells us what it needs. We both believe in the power of herbal remedies. However, while I see the connection between body and earth simply in terms of health, she goes a step further and sees the relationship as spiritual.

Listening to Sarah, a lot of the questions I have about Christianity resurfaced. Sarah's thoughts on life and religion are relatively simple. All it takes is belief in a world beyond the physical; in essence, a spiritual aspect to our existence. As she talked about psychology and

self-development, I questioned whether ‘God’s work in my life’ is really just me learning, growing, and maturing. I questioned whether surrounding myself with other believers is simply a form of confirmation bias and I questioned whether believing in a God who loves unconditionally is only a form of comfort- like a baby’s safety blanket.

I’ve questioned before whether God exists, but, in Spain, for the first time, I questioned my reality.

Since returning to Paris, I have reflected a lot on the experience. While cooking dinner one night and thinking over the conversations Sarah and I had had, I was suddenly overcome with a deep, innate conviction that God exists. It cut into the middle of my thought pattern like lightning, and set in like a heavy weight. I have never been so profoundly sure of anything. It seemed to me that what had been once a tight-fisted belief had now become an unshakable certainty.

As soon as I was assured of this certainty, my line of reflection changed. The aspects of Sarah’s beliefs that had resonated with me, while no longer challenging my belief in God, still continued to challenge my reality. Through my experience living here, studying at a French university, and communicating in a different language, I have realized that each culture has a different way of thinking. The difference in thought patterns is neither positive nor negative- just different. For example, in France, when making an argument, the point is not necessarily to come to a definite conclusion. Rather, one’s job is two-fold. You are to determine your stance and then to discuss the limits of your position. At the end of the discussion, the ‘answer’ is not a statement. It is a question. Differences in thinking such as this inherently determine the manner in which we perceive God, Scripture, and the application of Scripture.

In light of this awareness, I rethought the conversations between Sarah and myself. One idea that had resonated with me was the idea of our body’s spiritual relationship with nature as well as our spiritual relationship with our bodies. At first, the idea of ‘being one with nature’ had forced me to wrestle with the truth of Christianity. However, as I thought more about the idea the

week after, I began to ask myself whether the idea is really in conflict with Christianity- or just *my* Christianity.

In the United States, we grow up with a scientific mindset. We are taught to think in terms of facts, objective reality, what we can see with our eyes and prove with tests. This is why I was taught apologetics at my Christian school. We were to learn how to prove our faith to the rest of the world.

As a whole, the ‘other-worldly’ or the mystical are seen as fantastical in American culture. A story about a boy who was demon-possessed by a legion of demons for three days until a group of his friends had prayed each of the demons out would be seen as outlandish and beyond belief. In addition to non-Christians, I know many American Christians who would struggle to believe such an account. Yet I also know many non-American Christians who *would* believe it.

Either way, the story is true.

Thus, in an American Christian culture where science is the answer, the idea that our body and nature are linked in a spiritual sense and that it is important to be ‘at one with our body’ may seem incompatible with our faith. Many would call the idea blasphemous. Not so long ago I was in that camp. I listened to preachers who warned about the dangers of yoga and ‘Oriental practices.’

I am no longer in that camp.

I am no longer in that camp because I think as a result of our cultural thought patterns, we can miss out on aspects of God that other cultures see. As a result, I believe in the importance of listening to and understanding perspectives of other cultures.

Sarah is not a Christian. Her wisdom is not from above and thus I will always need to think critically about what she says and filter it through a biblical lens. However, I do think I can

still learn from Sarah. I believe that I have gained a better perspective from her on what God meant when He said of us in Genesis, “It is very good.” In seeing the spiritual relationship between us and nature, I see a God who harmonizes all things, as well as a beautiful picture of how He created Earth for us and us for Earth.

Thus when faced with the question of whether I would do yoga as a spiritual practice, the answer is yes. If asked whether I will meditate and focus on listening to the parts of my body, the answer is yes. If asked whether I believe humans have a spiritual relationship with nature, the answer is yes. And I believe that by focusing on this relationship, I can gain a better awareness of who God is and how He has made us.

Nevertheless, out of everything I gained from my experience in Spain, I think my most important takeaway was that, when I am confronted with thoughts and beliefs that differ from my own, I shouldn’t react with a defensive stance. Instead, I should ask myself what I can gain from a divergent perspective and how listening might widen my view of the Lord. Sometimes the ideas might run contrary to Biblical doctrine - like Sarah’s conception of past lives - but other times I might leave with a more complete view of the God in whom I believe. If I am able to enter discussions with a posture of openness, I will not face a crisis of faith as I did in Spain. If I am able to be open, my faith will learn to bend, not break.

Testimonies

Continually Chosen

Hannah Young

“Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who has blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in the heavenly places, even as he chose us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and blameless before him.”

Ephesians 1:3-4 (ESV)

Some of my earliest memories are tied to the church. Growing up, I consistently found myself at a small church each Sunday morning, soaking up the gospel story. Despite my regular attendance, I lacked the experience of discussing God with my peers. My church was home to only a few children my age, so many of my childhood conversations about faith were with my parents and grandparents. I learned a lot about God from these experiences, accepted Jesus, and was baptized in March 2018. I believed I had a solid understanding of who God is, although my faith remained childlike, but I still hadn't fully grasped what it meant to completely give my life to him.

As I grew older, the disconnect I felt between myself and others my age heightened. I went to three different school districts throughout my childhood, and as I am introverted at heart, it took me some time to make new friends each time I transferred schools. However, even once I did, I struggled to settle into the relationships I had formed, partly out of fear that I wouldn't be with them for much time anyways. Due to this separation I felt, both physically and mentally, I led myself to believe that other people might not want friendship with me because they didn't seem to make an effort to be my friend. I continually longed for a community of friends I could

rely on, who truly loved and cared for me, and afraid of what would happen if I wasn't ever chosen as a friend.

Moving into college, I nervously anticipated the need to make friends again. I dreaded that I would need to put myself out there and try to win the attention of new people. Desperately trying to avoid this reality and being so wrapped up in the anxiety that it brought me, I pushed my faith aside and clung to my introversion, busy schedule, and an existing surface-level friendship to occupy my time.

Regardless, I still went to church each Sunday and still held onto the faith I had formed as a child, although my faith felt like it was more that of my parents and grandparents than mine. The importance of prayer and reading scripture was always emphasized while growing up, but I rarely found myself doing either once I had gotten to college. I found my faith confined to church on Sunday mornings, and I didn't regularly practice my faith outside of this setting. Besides, religious activities outside of typical church services felt like a social situation, a setting in which it seemed everyone knew each other well and knew how to talk about God comfortably. It was one where I thought I would feel left out if I tried to insert myself.

At the end of the school year, I was feeling great. I looked back on all of the significant life steps I had taken and accomplishments that I had made, including forming some new friendships and maintaining those that I already had. I felt confident going into the summer, knowing I had completed a whole year in Ann Arbor. But upon returning home, I found those accomplishments in friendship crumbling down around me. In the span of one phone call, I learned that a friend of mine had never considered us friends and that he wasn't sure if he wanted to try and be friends with me anymore, that he wasn't sure if the effort was worth it. In that instant, I found all of my insecurities in friendship, or lack thereof, resurfacing. I felt unwanted and unloved and immediately began doubting the legitimacy of the personal growth I had thought was made during my first year of college.

Shortly after that, I was given an opportunity to assist with field work in Voyageurs National Park. During this trip, an ecology student was going to the park to collect samples from a variety of vernal pools. She would then use this data for a research paper that she was writing.

Her research partner was unable to go on the trip, and through a mutual connection, I was extended an invitation to fill the vacant spot. I had no prior experience doing field work and I had never met the woman who I would spend the week with. But, I thought that this trip could serve as a good distraction from the sadness I had been feeling. In a whirlwind of a few days, I found myself at her door one evening and driving to the park the following day.

Due to flooding around the park, we decided to leave our tent in the same spot each night, and take our canoe to paddle and hike to various study sites daily. Each evening, we had some time to kill after dinner, and my companion came much more prepared than I did, as she brought a book and a journal to occupy herself with. I, however, brought nothing of the sort and my phone had died on the car trip there. After each dinner, I found a spot to sit on the rocks next to the shore of the lake and spent time in silence and thought. The first night, I only sat in silence, milling over the loss of friendship I faced and feeling like I couldn't ever be wanted the way I wish I could be. Then, on the second night, I felt compelled to pray. Before this trip, the bulk of my prayer consisted of short prayers before mealtimes with my family; I had never genuinely prayed alone. But each night after that first prayer, I found myself returning deep in prayer repeatedly.

At first, I only asked God to rid me of my sadness and that perhaps this would all pan out and I would find reconciliation in this friendship. After all, this friend had told me he would call me after he returned from his summer internship. But as the week went on, I became more bold in my prayer, and I asked God why I made this friendship out to be more than it was, why God would place him into my life if he would only hurt me while he was there. I prayed over the loneliness that I was feeling, and I prayed over each person I had met at church in Ann Arbor during the past year that I had hidden from, despite their attempts to be my friend, even while I sought after friendship and community.

During these prayers, I felt God calling me to make more time for him and my relationship with him and build a community of faith with those he had already planted into my life. I recalled a conversation I had had that previous Spring, in which someone asked if I felt I was getting what I needed spiritually. I was much too stubborn, and I insisted that I was doing

fine, that I had enjoyed meeting everyone at church, and that it was merely my busy schedule holding me back from attending events outside of the regular church service. Looking back on it now, I see I was dishonest with myself. My faith had become a checklist item (and a relatively short list at that) in my life, and I wasn't entirely devoting myself to God and to building a community with his followers.

God had so clearly placed a group of people into my life who cared about me, how I was doing, and who shared a deep love of him. Yet, instead of following his plan for me to build a community of Christians, I chased after a one-sided friendship with a man who didn't truly care about me or my faith to momentarily satisfy my desire to feel needed.

Since my return from Voyageurs, I have been able to dive into my faith and make it my own, as well as lean into the community I have been blessed with in newfound vulnerability. I have grown in confidence in discussing God and have opened up about my faith with my roommates and others with whom I had never addressed faith prior to this change. Throughout it all, God was working through me, and he brought me right where I needed to be. Surrounded by the beauty of Voyageurs National Park, I couldn't help but see the hand of God in everything. I saw the consistency and love in his creation that week: the vernal pools we were studying needed conditions to be "just right" to support the lives of the frogs, salamanders, and fingernail clams. And amongst all of that, "The Spirit of God has made me, and the breath of the Almighty gives me life" (Job 33:4). He has chosen me from the start and continually chooses me each day. No matter the friendships that I had, or that I didn't have, or the ones that seemed to be running away from me faster than I could keep up, I have always had the love of God, and that would never change.

Creative Writing

Innermost Being

Sommer Motley

*Pieces of us, so darkly misconstrued in fear and insecurity,
Moments in which these pieces singularly tell our story,
Of weightful loss, searing pain, and spiteful infidelity,
Wrapped tightly in a box with no escape from our own hateful jury.*

*Drowning in the momentful sea of darkness night,
Light trapped outside the surface, bits shining in tiny rippled holes,
Rainy gray clouds, fog in our endless plight,
There is no rest for our tiresome souls.*

*We yearn to elucidate truth in our buried layers,
Streams of hope and love lie beneath the endless clouds,
Our cries heard in soundless, groaning prayers,
Reaching for a grasp on life on baseless grounds.*

*Still we know that we are more than a singularity,
Our lungs breathe in natural harmony with the passions of our heart,
Desires flock to countless, perfect stars of possibility,
Discontent to let our dreams fall apart.*

*Knocking on our battered walls of hopelessness opens way,
To the parts of us that aren't neatly wrapped in beautiful scars,
Cracking open the gate of all of the lies we tell ourselves night and day,
Bearing our souls to the sight of One far more perfect than we say.*

*God peers into our raging seas of imperfection and lying thoughts,
He sorts through the storm inside of us,
To set the story straight of what is and what is not.*

*For He made us in His perfect image in our mother's womb,
Knitting together our soul full of His goodness and love,
So that we may be witness to His great handiwork that heals all wounds,
That knows the innermost, darkest, and purest parts of ourselves.*

*We cannot hide nor can we lie to God about what is beneath our mask,
He formed your being and loves you beyond all measure,
Bringing lightness and hope to where you dared not ask,
For He cannot stand for darkness to win against His delightful treasure.*

He sees

He knows

He makes

He loves

Our innermost being.

I have always loved Psalm 139 and it often brings me to tears. It is easy for me to put a mask on for the world to see and hide behind it. Yet, I so desperately crave to be known and understood just as I am. I wrote this poem in a coffee shop in my hometown and thought about the little girl that had big dreams for the future, and how I still have those dreams. I flipped through my journal over the past year and realized how much I have overcome. Most people see my accomplishments and see my joy, but few truly know what lies beyond that. For me, God's perfect love comforts my desperate soul. He gives me life and hope for a world that is better and is the only One who gets to see all of the parts of me.

Privilege

Sommer Motley

In a world where winning and success

Rule over love and compassion

There is hatred.

There is power.

For Christ died for our sins

We sin away at the people He

Died for.

They are too lazy

Too poor, too desperate

To make righteous choices

To win the salvation that they so freely have.

We tell them it is not I

But the system of which lives

In us.

Our hands are tied,

Our hands nailed to keep us free of the blood that sheds from our palms.

Our head crowned with the thorns of

Whipping and tearing

Our brothers and sisters.

But yet Christ for us

And Christ in us.

For if God is for us

Who

Can

Be

Against us.

What once was crowned with thorns

Is now put in glory now,

Forgetting the bloody

Stones beneath their feet.

We walk on our clean feet,

Forgetting that we too need

Them washed free.

As children of the royal king

We think, we choose

Who is us

and who is them.

We forget who our king is.

Whose hands bled for us

Not of us.

We forget that we are not our own savior,

We are not clean, we are not yet free.

*For if we nail our hands to
Forbid us of guilt,
We still bleed just the same.*

Living in Memphis, Tennessee last summer opened my eyes to some of the great disparities of this world. My heart breaks for the injustice that my brothers and sisters face. It further breaks my heart that Christians are at times the ones advocating for this disparity, or even worse bystanders. There is a sense of self-righteousness among Christians and a hesitation to stand up for others. The privilege that we have is held so deeply in pride that we only look beyond ourselves when it suits us. I wrote this poem to provoke emotion for what at times is hard to grasp and understand. I wrote this poem out of frustration and out of plight for a more Jesus-like society.

Except

Eli Grewell

Depression

Wondering.

Waiting.

Waiting for the moment where everything gets better

Waiting for the inspiration to really get it together.

Waiting for a reason to get up

To get out of bed

To start my day and thank God I'm not dead.

Constant monotony

A monochromatic atrocity

Every day devoid of meaning

Simply living because I haven't found a reason not to be.

Suicidal thoughts rampage my head

Every fiber of my being leaving me for dead

Beaten and abused

EDs and scars

Searching for an answer that can cure a broken heart

Is there anyone out there?

Where have you gone?

The pain's too much to handle

I don't know how to carry on.

There's so much darkness inside me

There's no way to let it out

An external facade but inside I want to shout
Only once hidden
Locked within my room
Do I break down
And fantasize my doom

Except...

Loneliness

Surrounded by smiling face after smiling face
Yet deep inside my heart still aches.
Billions of people, but no one to let in
Hoping and praying for love to begin
Tears welling up, but held back by a grin
No one can see the pain deep within

Is it too much to ask
To be someone's first choice?
For someone to truly just listen to my voice?

Looking around
Everyone else
Seems to have found
Their people that they are always around
A group to pick them up when they're feeling down
Do I fit in?
Am I just a joke?
When I hear my name it's 'cause someone misspoke

Where do I go with this hole in my chest?
A desire for community, but I'm an outcast
Always coming in last
With no place to call home
Just me and my thoughts, once again, all alone.

Except...

Anxiety

You will never be good enough
Is what I often hear.
Nobody likes you
Why are you even here?
Imposter syndrome undermines my every achievement
A man at war with himself, the epitome of disagreement

Every day thoughts pulverize the recesses of my mind
Hoping to destroy any peace that I may find
Straining relationships because of how I'm defined
I am defined in my mind, by what I'm told I'm not
I'm not attractive enough
Not athletic enough
I'll never be enough
A need for people-pleasing poisons my control
It's hard to still find value when the world demeans my soul
A fight between my mind and heart
All orientation gets torn apart

If I was truly worth it, why's society begging me to depart?

No reason for a search for peace

No hope to find shalom

A constant drowning feeling

Is all I've ever known

The suffocating stress submerges me in the waters of despair

Every day's a constant battle, just to breach and breathe the air

Except...

Addiction

Just one more

Just one more

I don't want to feel anymore

Until I'm lying there, blacked out on the floor

Until I can't remember what I started drinking for

A million different feelings

All too much to comprehend.

Turning to the bottle is like turning to a friend

Trying everything just to get the pain to end

A sweet blissful high

To the psychedelic flow

Nowhere else to turn to

'Cause this is all I truly know.

A desperation for pleasure and "what is in it for me"

Is what keeps me imprisoned in the lies of pornography

Every moment of weakness

Every heartache and desire

Squeezes the chains of addiction just a little bit tighter

Until soon enough there's no going back

A life defeated, sent down the wrong track

Homelessness

Abuse

Failed marriages and broken homes

Addiction pillages and plunders leaving nothing but bare bones

Little aspiration besides satisfying the longing

Shells of former selves simply striving toward belonging

Except...

Except

Except..

Because of Jesus we have been set free!

The Savior of the world, nailed to that cursed tree

Bore our sin and our shame as he died on Calvary

We therefore do not have to live in these lies and this deception

For the world was forever changed with Jesus' resurrection!

A monochromatic atrocity

Turns to a vibrant display of artistry

As the power of the All Mighty God is reflected for all of Earth to see

The world feeds us lies
The devil spurs us towards death
But the God of the Universe didn't spend his last breath
Saying "Forgive them, they know not what they do"
Just for us to bow down to the devil
And place Jesus back in that tomb.

So why waste your time with the devil and his schemes
When we are called to serve a resurrected king.
A king who keeps no record of wrong
A king who died at the hands of a throng
Who beat him and cursed him and mocked him all day long
A king who forgave these men while strung up on that cross
A king whose death caused death's biggest loss.
If the God of the Universe died for your sin
Gave you forgiveness when you drove nails through his skin
Then why do you live with such pain deep within?

You are NOT defined by your addiction
Your anxiety
Your loneliness
Your depression
You are FORGIVEN
You are NOT worthless
You are NOT broken
You are one of God's children
So leave the past in the past, it's time to truly start livin'

All we simply need is to embrace the love of the Father
Who tells us that we are his beloved son or his beloved daughter
It is true that we will never be good enough
But the Lord is our redeemer
Since we believe in the gospel, this has changed our whole demeanor
And God has never made a mistake
Trust me, you will not be the first
God has seen you at your best and he has seen you at your worst
And yet he still chooses you
Despite all your flaws
A relentless pursuit to rescue you from sin's jaws

Every trial we face simply signifies God's power
It's Satan's desperate attempt at victory in his final hours.
When Jesus died and rose again three days later
Hell's gates were broken down
And death was defeated by the mighty Creator.
His hands and his feet are not a sign of our failure
It's a sign that the Earth has finally received its Savior.
And the whole world needs to know why we live in such freedom
That we live for his kingdom
And that his name is Jesus.

My Faithful Shepherd Carries Me

Kevin Fan

Psalm 28: 8-9

[Verse 1]

My Faithful Shepherd carries me,
He loves me, this I know;
For He bore my sins on Calv'ry's cross
And He paid redemption's toll.
Look therefore up, O broken heart,
To see Him on that tree;
For He hung there as the Lamb of God
And He gave His life for thee.

[Verse 2]

My Strength and Shield is ever near,
I do not walk alone;
For He rose again from certain death
And He raises now His own.
Look therefore now, O eyes alight,
To see that empty grave;
For the Lord who lives forevermore
Is a Christ who loves to save.

[Verse 3]

My firm foundation ever holds,

He will not lose His own;
For He promises to see me through
And He'll call me safely home.
Look therefore past, O weary soul,
The trials of this life;
For your life is hid with Christ in God,
And your soul is sealed on high.

[Verse 4]

The Great I AM is on His throne,
His presence ever near;
I'll be found in Him on Judgment Day,
And He'll wipe away my tears.
Watch caref'ly then, O yearning one,
He will not tarry long;
For His saints will see Him face-to-face
And rejoice in heavn'ly song.

Though I Am Just A Sojourner

Kevin Fan

Psalm 39:12

[Verse 1]

Though I am just a sojourner
Who knows none else but strife,
I fix my eyes on the Lamb of God
Who died to give me life.
His posture is of steadfast love,
His countenance of grace;
His heart bestows a charity
That gladly takes my place.

[Verse 2]

Though I am but a wretched man
Who knows no righteous deeds,
I turn my gaze to Christ the Lord,
For His blood covers me.
His marvelous glory is unveiled
In resurrection life,
Where by trusting in the Risen Son
Is my soul justified.

[Verse 3]

Though I possess a feeble heart

And ever-wandering eyes,
The rod of Christ with chastening
Directs them toward the prize.
I know that He is with me
On this hard and narrow way;
Though there be many dangers here
With Him I will be safe.